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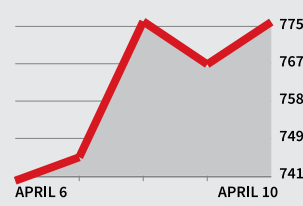
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IN FOCUS

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Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	149725.00	+388
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	239934.00	+3776

POLLSCAPE.

BJP's manifesto for Bengal promises UCC, anti-infiltration measures, welfare schemes for women, youth and farmers **p5**



AUTO FOCUS.

Triumph downsizes 400 cc bikes; minor performance drop, prices ease, but ride quality is excellent **p4**

QUICKLY.

NEW FLIGHTPATH

'Air India at critical stage of transformation'



New Delhi: The Tata Group remains committed to building a world-class Air India, even as the airline navigates a challenging operating environment, Tata Sons Chairman N Chandrasekaran said on Friday. Addressing an employee town hall at Air India Group's headquarters in Gurugram, Chandrasekaran said the airline had reached a "critical stage" in its transformation journey. **p2**

IRAN WAR IMPACT

LPG usage slumps to 21-month low in March

New Delhi: The consumption of liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) by India, the world's third largest consumer, fell by almost 16 per cent month-on-month and 13 per cent year-on-year to 2.38 million tonnes in March on a provisional basis — the lowest in the last 21 months. However, the consumption of diesel and petrol hit a record high last month at 8.73 mt and 3.78 mt respectively, aided by panic buying. **p3**

Despite a wobbly market, SIP flows hit record high in March

ADVANTAGE MFs. This underscores preference for disciplined, long-term investing

Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai

Record inflows via systematic investment plans (SIPs) pushed the overall investments in equity MFs to an eight-month high in March despite markets wobbling as the West Asia war raged on.

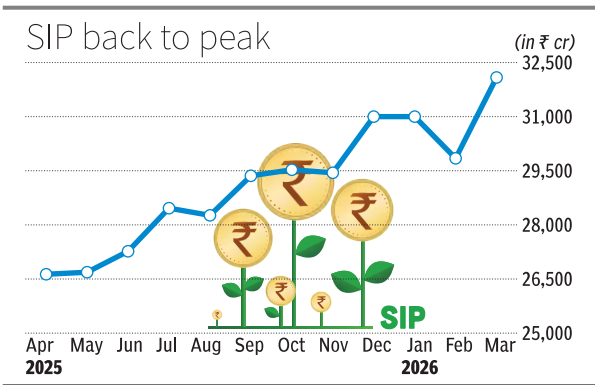
Continued investments by retail investors saw SIP inflows rise 8 per cent to ₹32,087 crore last month, up from ₹29,845 crore in February, as the contributing SIP accounts increased to 9.72 crore (9.44 crore).

However, the assets under SIPs plunged 9 per cent to ₹15.11 lakh crore (₹16.64 lakh crore) due to mark-to-market loss.

STEADFAST ON EQUITY

Navneet Munot, MD and CEO, HDFC Asset Management Company, said that despite the heightened volatility driven by geopolitical developments, investors remained steadfast and continued to invest with conviction, which augurs well for the long-term stability and depth of capital markets.

The strong SIP inflows un-



derscore the growing preference for disciplined and long-term equity investing, which reflects the increasing resilience of investors, he added.

Equity mutual fund inflows increased 56 per cent to ₹40,450 crore in March compared to ₹25,978 crore logged in February as investors took advantage of the sharp fall in equities to pump in more money.

Pankaj Shrestha, Head of Investment Services, PL Wealth Management, said the strong equity inflows, despite March being one of the most volatile months in recent times, reflect the robust investor conviction in

the long-term equity story.

Rather than being deterred by short-term fluctuations, investors used the opportunity to increase their equity allocations, resulting in record SIP inflows, he added.

Vaibhav Chugh, CEO, Abakks Mutual Fund, said investors have been seeing every fall in the market as an opportunity to invest rather than exit. Despite weak performance by small-caps for some time now, investors added allocations as they see valuations drop from 10-year averages, he added.

The overall equity assets under management plunged 10 per cent last month to

₹31.98 lakh crore (₹35.39 lakh crore) due to mark-to-market losses, according to the Association of Mutual Funds in India data released on Friday.

INDIA STORY INTACT

AMFI CEO Venkat Chalasani said retail investors had reposed faith in MF investments even when the markets were very volatile on the back of geopolitical tensions and inflation worries. India's long-term economic growth story, led by buoyant consumption, remains intact, and this will support SIP inflows, he added.

DEBT FUND OUTFLOWS

Debt funds registered outflows of ₹2.94 lakh crore, with almost all the schemes registering a net exit due to advance tax commitment before the quarter ended.

Despite the mark-to-market losses in MF equity schemes, assets of Specialised Investment Funds increased 9 per cent to ₹10,620 crore against ₹9,711 crore in February as fund houses used the equity derivatives market to hedge investments.

Asset size to classify NBFC Upper Layer; RBI proposes ₹1 lakh crore threshold

Our Bureau
Mumbai

In a major overhaul of the methodology for identification of non-banking finance companies (NBFCs) in the Upper Layer (UL), the RBI plans to move away from the current parametric scoring methodology to one based on asset size.

Under the proposed overhaul, Upper Layer NBFCs, which are tightly regulated and supervised by the RBI, will comprise those with assets of ₹1 lakh crore and above as per the latest audited balance sheet for the financial year.

Further, government-owned NBFCs will be brought under the Framework for Scale-based Regulation of NBFCs, removing the arbitrage they enjoyed *vis-à-vis* private sector NBFCs, per the draft RBI guidelines. So, state-owned NBFCs such as PFC, REC and IRFC could be classified as NBFC-UL.

PARAMETRIC SCORING

Currently, Upper Layer NBFCs are identified by way of a parametric scoring methodology, comprising quantitative and qualitative parameters as well as supervisory judgment. This includes those with an asset size of less than ₹1 lakh



crore. There were 15 NBFCs in the Upper Layer under the RBI's scale-based regulation in 2024-25. It included LIC Housing Finance, Bajaj Finance, Shriram Finance, Tata Sons, Cholamandalam Investment and Finance, Tata Capital, Mahindra & Mahindra Financial Services, Aditya Birla Finance and Muthoot Finance.

So far as Tata Sons is concerned, nothing much changes as its balancesheet size is well above the threshold, and it is up to the RBI to take a call on classifying it as an NBFC-UL.

Sanjay Agarwal, Senior Director, CareEdge Ratings, said: "The RBI wants to give guidance to the market that identification of NBFCs in the Upper Layer will not be discretionary. It will be in black and white, based on asset size. So, the ₹1 lakh crore asset size criteria for placing an NBFC in the UL is a clear signal to those reaching this threshold to start preparing

for an enhanced regulatory framework."

He assessed that two or three private sector NBFCs could be out of the RBI's UL list. However, the list will include large government-owned NBFCs.

Agarwal observed that for NBFCs in the UL, the level of regulatory compliance goes up, and their organisational structure has to be moulded in line with the requirements for this layer.

He pointed out that it is not clear from the draft directions if consolidated assets of an NBFC, which has subsidiaries, will be taken into account under the proposed asset size criteria for classifying it an Upper Layer outfit.

GOVT-OWNED NBFCs

Further, the inclusion of government-owned entities, too, based on their size, indicates a more harmonised way of identifying NBFC-UL. Based on the existing position, the number of NBFC-UL would go up *vis-à-vis* the 15 entities identified previously.

As per the draft directions, the criteria for identification of NBFC-UL shall be reviewed periodically. Further, the asset size threshold for identification of NBFC-UL shall be reviewed every five years.

West Asia supplies uncertain, India to buy Russian oil even after sanctions waiver ends

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

Indian refiners will continue to purchase Russian crude oil as the West Asia turmoil keeps global supplies on tenterhooks.

Further, concerns persist over the long time it will take to rebuild the region's damaged oil and gas infrastructure, indicating that it may take months for supplies to return to pre-war levels.

SUPPLY CONCERNS

Sources indicated that Indian refiners intend to persist with Russian crude purchases despite the expiration of the sanctions waiver.

The 30-day US sanctions exemption, which facilitated oil imports from Moscow, ends on April 11. The contin-



WAIVER DEADLINE. The 30-day US sanctions exemption, which facilitated oil imports from Moscow, ends on April 11

ued Russian buying is because of the uncertainty over supplies from West Asia, especially considering the lack of clarity on when normal traffic will resume in the Strait of Hormuz.

Also, there is no clear estimation of the time it will take to rebuild the damaged infrastructure, said one of the sources.

"The supplies of crude oil, LNG and LPG from Saudi

Arabia, Iraq, the UAE and Qatar are adversely impacted, and so far there is no clear window of certainty on when full supplies can resume," said another trading source.

Before February 28, West Asia accounted for 50-52 per cent of India's total crude oil imports compared to roughly 40-45 per cent before the US sanctions on Russian firms Rosneft and

Lukoil. Currently, around 70 per cent of India's crude oil imports are non-SoH.

Asked at the inter-ministerial briefing on Friday if India will continue procuring Russian crude post the end of the US-sanctions waiver, Sujata Sharma, Joint Secretary, Oil Ministry, said crude imports are based on commercial decisions, keeping in mind the country's huge demand.

"We are a big country with a lot of energy needs. If you look at last year's consumption, it is around 24-25 crore tonnes of petroleum products. Our priority is to source energy so that we can meet our domestic demand. The crude we purchase is driven by technical feasibility and the commercial sense it makes to our refiners," she said.

CROP CONCERNS



RAINS PLAY SPOILSPORT. A farm worker winnows wheat at a field near Bhopal on Friday. Unseasonal showers and hailstorms in March and April have affected the wheat crop across 111 districts in nine States, resulting in an estimated 5-10 per cent decline in overall production. The government had earlier estimated wheat production this year at a record 120.21 million tonnes **ANI**

Shapoorji Pallonji Mistry reiterates call for public listing of Tata Sons, cites long-term stakeholder value

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Shapoorji Pallonji Mistry on Friday reiterated his call for a timely public listing of Tata Sons, asserting that such a move is essential for strengthening corporate governance, transparency, accountability and long-term stakeholder value.

"To date, no clear, evidence-based case has been presented to explain how a public listing would materially damage the interests of the trusts or reduce their ability to serve beneficiaries," he said, adding that the listing was "fundamentally in public interest".

RENEWED PUSH

This is the second time in six months that the SP Group, the largest minority shareholder in Tata Sons, is pushing publicly for a listing. The statement comes as two



The SP Group and the Tata Sons leadership are in constructive engagement to reach an amicable reconciliation at the earliest

SHAPOORJI PALLONJI MISTRY
Chairman, Shapoorji Pallonji Pvt Ltd



the Reserve Bank of India for a decisive direction with regard to the listing," he added.

The listing of the Tata Group's holding company should not be viewed merely as a regulatory requirement, but as a necessary evolution aligning with the group's foundational principles of accountability and public purpose, he said.

IN PUBLIC INTEREST

Mistry emphasised that listing Tata Sons would be in the broader public interest, as it would enhance board accountability, widen the investor base and unlock value for retail shareholders.

He added that it would create a more stable and transparent dividend stream for the trusts, thereby expanding their philanthropic impact, particularly for underserved sections of society. The SP Group is pushing for a listing to monetise its stake and use the proceeds to pare its debt.

Why the ₹5 pack won't disappear, but only get lighter

With input cost pressures rising, FMCG firms trim quantity to avoid price hikes

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

The humble ₹5 biscuit pack has survived demonetisation, GST, Covid and repeated commodity tremors. It now faces the shock of crude above \$100 a barrel, palm oil supplies tightening and polymer prices continuing to rise, but looks set to survive this setback as well. Only, it will weigh a tad less.

PRICE SANCTITY

FMCG companies are facing a fresh cost squeeze. Nuvama Institutional Equities estimated that the current commodity basket could shave off 100-250 basis points from gross margins if companies do not act.

EY India's Angshuman Bhattacharya called it a "system-wide cost surge" that will translate into higher prices or grammage cuts.

Price shift

(MRP in ₹)

Product	After GST 2.0 (December 2025)	March 2026
	Weight Revised MRP after GST 2.0	Weight Current MRP
Parle-G	200+50 g 27	200+50 g 30
Parle-G	80+10 g 9	80+10 g 10
Melody	391 g 89	391 g 100
Melody	3.128 kg 712	3.128 kg 800

But the ₹5 and ₹10 price points remain sacrosanct. "These entry-level packs will not disappear because they anchor rural India's consumption economy, where purchases are often made daily. Even a marginal hike risks pushing consumers out of the category altogether," an industry analyst said.

As a result, companies are cutting quantity rather than raising prices. Parle has trimmed the grammage of Parle-G packs to retain the ₹5 and ₹10 price points.

Varun Beverages has

launched ultra-small ₹10 packs of Pepsi and Slice, while Dabur and Emami are pushing smaller packs across honey, juices and personal care.

SILENT SHRINKAGE

Nuvama noted that Britannia and Nestlé are being "surgical" in their approach, reducing pack sizes of Good Day, Marie Gold and Maggi while protecting the premium segments. Packaging, which accounts for 15-20 per cent of costs, has become a key pressure point amid polymer inflation.

Dhairyashil Patil, National President of AICPDF (All India Consumer Products Distributors Federation), called grammage cuts a silent killer, with consumers often unaware they are getting less for the same ₹5 or ₹10. A ₹10 Good Day pack, he said, has dropped from 100 g to about 90 g, while ₹10 soaps such as Lifebuoy and Lux have been trimmed by 8-12 g and Dettol bars from 45 g to about 40. Even the ₹5 Vim bar is now 5-7 g lighter.

"Such pricing actions could weigh on the nascent demand recovery," Anand Rath Research cautioned.

Each cost cycle resets the baseline lower. What begins as a temporary adjustment becomes permanent. For companies, this protects margins; for consumers, it quietly raises the effective price of everyday goods.

CM
YK

QUICKLY.
Forex reserves rise
\$9 billion to \$697 billion



Mumbai: The country's forex reserves jumped by \$9.063 billion to \$697.121 billion for the week ended April 3, 2026, the Reserve Bank of India said on Friday. In the previous reporting week, which ended on March 27, the overall reserves had dropped by \$10.288 billion to \$688.058 billion. For the week ended April 3, foreign currency assets increased by \$1.784 billion to \$552.856 billion. **PTI**

Iranian oil tankers allowed to berth for Reliance

New Delhi: The Shipping Ministry has granted special permission to four vessels carrying Iranian oil — as requested by Reliance Industries — to berth at Sikka, three industry sources said. One of the sources said the Shipping Ministry has granted a special one-time exemption to vessels requested by Reliance due to the emergency situation created by the closure of the Strait of Hormuz. **REUTERS**

LPG usage slumps to 21-month low in March amid supply disruption

FUEL FRENZY. Diesel and petrol sales are at a record high, aided by panic buying on account of the Iran war

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

The consumption of liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) by India, the world's third largest consumer, fell by almost 16 per cent m-o-m and 13 per cent y-o-y to 2.38 million tonnes (mt) on a provisional basis — the lowest in the last 21 months.

Simultaneously, the consumption of diesel and petrol hit a record high last month at 8.73 mt and 3.78 mt, respectively, aided by panic buying as consumers crowded at retail outlets fearing hit on supplies due to the conflict in West Asia, even as the government has reiterated that there are "sufficient" supplies available.

Data from the Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell (PPAC) show that the LPG's monthly decline of 15.7 per cent in March 2026 is a record low. Prior to this, the lowest consumption was re-



IN SHORT SUPPLY. People waiting outside a gas agency in Kanpur, Uttar Pradesh, on Friday **PTI**

corded in June 2024 (2.32 mt).

CUMULATIVE USAGE
Overall, India's cumulative LPG consumption rose by 6 per cent y-o-y to 33.21 mt on a provisional basis. This is the highest annual growth in usage since FY19.

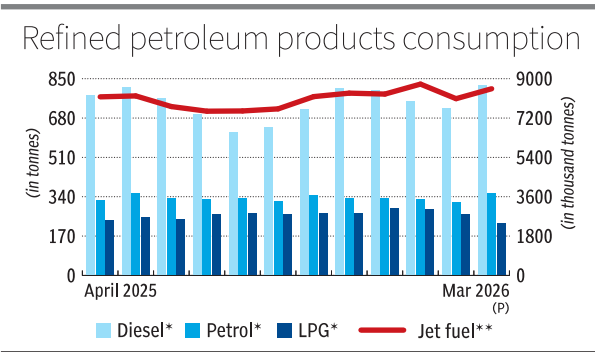
A senior government official said "LPG is the sharpest pressure point. India imports 60 per cent of its LPG with 90 per cent of that transiting Hormuz. This impacted imports, which fell to around 1.1 mt last month from roughly 2 mt in February. This is among the

sharpest monthly falls in imports."

However, the government has been quick to tackle the situation by re-prioritising energy resources.

With LPG, the priority is households as 90-92 per cent of the annual LPG consumption is there. That apart, the Oil Ministry has also pushed piped natural gas (PNG) and the expectation is that there will be around 6-7 lakh new consumers by April-end with more than 3 lakh already onboard in March 2026, he added.

Another notable development is that India's diesel



consumption during March 2026 has hit a record high at 8.73 mt (provisionally). It rose by 14 per cent m-o-m and 8 per cent y-o-y. Prior to this, the highest consumption was in May 2025 at 8.57 mt.

PETROL AT A NEW HIGH
Similarly, the consumption of petrol also hit a record high of 3.78 mt (provisionally), growing by 12 per cent m-o-m and almost 8 per cent Y-o-Y.

Prior to this, the highest usage was recorded in May

2025 at 3.78 mt. The trends in usage are led by the conflict in West Asia. The world's second largest LPG importer procures almost 60 per cent of its consumption from the Middle East Gulf (MEG) region with most cargo transiting the Strait of Hormuz (SoH).

The closure of the critical energy choke point since February 28, 2026 severely impacted India's imports, which in normal times stood at around 54,000 tonnes per day (TPD) and has come down to around 30,000 TPD.

Govt defers power plant maintenance for 3 months

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

The Power Ministry assured on Friday that India's power sector is "adequately positioned" to meet short-term and long-term demand adding that as an extra precaution it has deferred maintenance shutdowns at thermal power plants (TPPs), unlocking around 10,000 MW of capacity.

Piyush Singh, Additional Secretary at the Power Ministry, said at the inter-ministerial briefing on West Asia on Friday that in light of the ongoing geopolitical tensions in West Asia and rising volatility in global energy markets, the Ministry of Power has undertaken a comprehensive review of India's power sector preparedness.

In the short term, Singh explained that the Ministry has directed that planned maintenance of TPPs is being deferred to ensure availability of adequate generation capacity during April to June 2026, which will unlock around 10,000 MW additional capacity. This additional capacity will help compensate for around 8,000 MW of gas-based power capacity that is struggling for want of supplies due to the West Asian conflict.

Besides, the Ministry is also accelerating commis-



SURGING DEMAND. Adequate coal stock is being ensured at thermal power plants to address near-term supply challenges

sioning of under construction projects — thermal, hydro, solar, wind, hybrid, battery energy storage system (BESS), pumped storage project (PSP) during April-June, 2026. This includes 3,500 MW coal fired capacity, 10,000 MW solar power and 2,500 MW wind power.

"India's current installed capacity of over 531,000 MW reflects a well-diversified portfolio, with significant contributions from coal, renewables, hydro, and nuclear sources, with non-fossil sources exceeding 50 per cent.

COAL STOCK
This capacity is supported by a strong transmission backbone of approximately 5 lakh circuit kilometres (ckm) and over 120,000 MW inter-regional transfer capability, ensuring reliable power flow

across regions," he noted. Besides, adequate coal stock is being ensured at thermal power plants to address near-term supply challenges. Currently, the stock is around 55 million tonnes, which is sufficient for 19 days. Imported coal-based (ICB) plants are being fully operationalised to maximise existing capacity.

India's peak power demand is expected at around 271,000 MW in 2026 from 245,000 MW in 2025 and 250,000 MW in 2024.

Policy measures, including 10-year resource adequacy planning by states, green energy corridors, interstate transmission charge waivers, and schemes such as PM-KUSUM, PM Surya Ghar, and the National Green Hydrogen Mission are supporting the transition, the ministry said.

Rubio's India visit in May to focus on trade, tariffs

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

US Secretary of State Marco Rubio is slated to arrive in India next month for his first official visit since taking office amid deepening disruptions across West Asia and continued tariff uncertainty in Washington.

US Ambassador to India Sergio Gor announced Rubio's expected visit to India next month after Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri's meeting with Rubio in Washington DC on Thursday.

"Welcome to the White House Vikram Misri! Productive meeting with Secretary Rubio that focused on our bilateral relationship, especially trade, critical minerals, defense and the Quad. Secretary Rubio looks forward to visiting India next month!" Gor posted in social media platform 'X'.

Earlier on Thursday, Gor had announced that a high-level Indian delegation will visit Washington later this month, in an indication of efforts to finalise the proposed interim trade deal. The Commerce & Industry is yet to make an official announcement on the visit but officials confirmed that plans were being worked out.

INDIA-US TRADE
In the area of trade, the US wants to revive talks on the India-US interim bilateral trade agreement that lost



Marco Rubio, US Secretary of State

momentum after the US Supreme Court ruled against the reciprocal tariffs imposed by the Donald Trump regime on most of its trade partners.

The US tends to gain significantly from the interim trade deal as India, under the framework pact, had agreed to eliminate or sharply reduce tariffs for most industrial goods and also lower duties on a wide range of US agricultural and food products.

Growing cooperation between India and the US in critical minerals will also be prominently on Rubio's agenda. By aligning on mineral security, the two nations are trying to ensure that the raw materials for future semiconductors and green energy remain insulated from geopolitical shocks in the Indo-Pacific, and dependence on China goes down.

Rubio's visit is also expected to focus on re-energising the Quad grouping of India, the US, Australia and Japan.

Induction cooking may consume 13-27 GW power

Rishi Ranjan Kala
Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

As the sale of electricity-based cooking equipment, such as induction cooktops, is gaining traction with consumers adding an alternative to LPG, the government estimates that the cumulative electricity consumption from this could be in the range of 13-27 gigawatts (GW).

According to government officials, industry executives and analysts, sales of induction cooktops have surged dramatically in the past four weeks in metros and tier-II cities such as Kanpur, Indore, Pune, Nagpur and Hyderabad.

Before the start of the current hostilities in West Asia (February 28), the demand for induction cooktop was largely concentrated in tier-II and tier-III towns.

POWER CONSUMPTION
Asked about electricity consumption from induction cooktops, Piyush Singh, Additional Secretary at the Power Ministry, said: "The transition towards induction-based cooking is expected to introduce an additional layer of demand at the distribution level, potentially influencing overall load patterns, particularly during morning and evening peak

India, Japan discuss Strait of Hormuz security

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

As the world grappled with the cascading fallout of the West Asian conflict, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar on Friday spoke to his Japanese counterpart Toshimitsu Motegi largely focusing on passage of ships through the Strait of Hormuz.

Motegi also conveyed Japan's condolences on the killing of a number of Indians in the conflict. Since the hostilities began on February 28, eight Indian nationals have been killed and several others injured in the region.

"Good to speak with FM Toshimitsu Motegi of Japan. Discussed developments in West Asia, including international shipping through the Strait of Hormuz. Appreciate his condolences for the Indian lives lost in the conflict," Jaishankar said on social media.

SAFE NAVIGATION
Motegi said he and Jaishankar discussed the current situation in West Asia including ensuring the safety of navigation through the Strait of Hormuz. The Japanese foreign min-

ister welcomed the recent announcement by the US and Iran on a two-week ceasefire.

"He also stated that what matters most is that de-escalation, including the safety of navigation through the Strait of Hormuz, is steadily achieved, and expressed his hopes that a final agreement will be reached promptly through the negotiations between the United States and Iran," according to a Japanese readout.

Motegi further stated that he would like to closely co-ordinate with the international community, including India on the issue.

"In response, Minister Jaishankar stated that India will continue to work closely with Japan so that de-escalation of the situation would be realised, including the safety of navigation through the Strait of Hormuz," the Japanese readout noted.

"Both Ministers concurred that Japan and India will continue to communicate closely with each other. Furthermore, both ministers concurred on promoting co-operation, including Japan and India, to enhance the resiliency of energy and resource supply," it said.



The India induction cooktop market size is in the range of ₹7,600-8,000 crore

shortage; however, over the past two months, demand has surged in metros as well, a significant shift that we have observed."

Ravi Saxena, Founder & CEO of Wonderchef, said, "We have been witnessing high demand across the country for induction cooktops both from metros and tier-2 cities."

HIGHER DEMAND
Wonderchef has been witnessing nearly 10 times higher demand for induction cooktops, he noted.

"Given the long-term impact of the disruptions due to the West Asia crisis, we believe this demand is not for the short-term but will continue in the long-term. Potentially, every LPG connection household is today looking at buying an induction cooktop as an alternative especially since the price barrier is low. In fact, the demand has been higher than supply and there have been stock out situations too," Saxena pointed out.

Besides, the government is also looking at measures to encourage companies to ramp up production of induction heaters, induction cooktops and compatible utensils. This comes at a time when these categories are witnessing high demand due to concerns over LPG availability amidst the West Asia conflict.

Govt proposes overhaul of company incorporation rules

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

In a move aimed at easing the process of setting up companies, the government has proposed amendments to the Companies (Incorporation) Rules, 2014, including doing away with mandatory physical verification of registered offices in all cases and introducing norms to address liabilities of deceased subscribers in newly incorporated entities.

The Ministry of Corporate Affairs, in a draft notification released for public comments, said the proposed changes seek to simplify procedures, reduce duplicate filings, expand the use of electronic communication and align incorporation processes with other regulatory frameworks such as GST and the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC).

EXPERTS' TAKE
Legal experts view the proposed changes as a significant step towards reducing procedural hurdles for businesses. Ricky Chopra of Ricky Chopra International

Counsels said the reforms could materially ease operational and procedural aspects of setting up companies.

"The red tape ensuing from elongated paperwork is clearly shown the door, and bringing together of multiple forms into a couple of e-forms will be instrumental in avoiding filing delays," Chopra said, adding that measures such as liberalised Director Identification Number allotments and removal of bulk affidavits could encourage greater participation from investor-led businesses and MSMEs.

Moin Ladha, Partner at Khaitan & Co, said the amendments signal a shift from a documentation-heavy approach to a more practical, risk-based framework. According to him, the proposals address longstanding gaps such as subscriber liability in the event of death, while easing compliance requirements at the entry stage.

Under the draft, physical verification of registered offices by the registrar would no longer be mandatory in all cases. Instead, verification

● **EASING HURDLES**
The proposed changes seek to simplify procedures, reduce duplicate filings, expand the use of electronic communication and align incorporation processes with other regulatory frameworks

may be conducted through an authorised person, in the presence of two local witnesses and, where required, with assistance from local police, based on available information and documents. This effectively introduces a risk-based and need-based approach to inspections.

The draft also proposes expanding the list of acceptable documents and providing clearer scenarios for verification of registered offices. According to Manvinder Singh, Partner at JSA Advocates & Solicitors, this could particularly benefit companies operating from co-working spaces or located in special economic zones (SEZs), where documentation requirements have often been

ambiguous. However, Singh cautioned that clearer guidance may still be required to ensure uniform implementation across jurisdictions.

KEY PROPOSAL
Another key proposal is the insertion of a new rule to address cases where a subscriber to a company dies before paying for shares subscribed at the time of incorporation, excluding One Person Companies.

Under the proposed rule, the legal representative of the deceased subscriber would be required to pay the unpaid subscription amount. Once payment is made, the legal representative would assume the rights of the original subscriber, effectively stepping into their position.

While the provision seeks to resolve a long-standing grey area in company law, experts warn that it may create practical challenges. Singh said that issues could arise where legal representatives are unaware of subscription obligations, succession disputes exist, or heirs are unwilling to assume financial liabilities, potentially complicating enforcement.

Invesco Mutual Fund

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Disclosure of Half-Yearly Portfolio Statement of schemes of Invesco Mutual Fund

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For Invesco Asset Management (India) Pvt. Ltd.
(Investment Manager for Invesco Mutual Fund)

Sd/-

Saurabh Nanavati

Managing Director & Chief Executive Officer

Date: April 10, 2026

Mutual Fund investments are subject to market risks, read all scheme related documents carefully.

Fair deal

SEBI must move on restoring open market buybacks

The world over, securities market laws look favourably upon companies buying back their own shares. Indian regulations have however flip-flopped on this issue. Since April 2025, companies have been barred from buying back shares through the open market route. However, share buybacks are necessary for the free flow of capital within the market ecosystem. Therefore, it is good to see a Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) consultation paper, which proposes to bring back buybacks through the open market route.



There were two major reasons why open market buybacks were frowned upon. One, they were seen as inequitable to shareholders. In the tender offer route, all shareholders get an opportunity to offer their shares to the company, which are then proportionately accepted. In market buybacks, only select investors who sell in the market while the buyback window is open get to participate. However, market buybacks are not as unfair as they seem. Regulations require companies to make public announcements of buyback programmes much ahead of the event, giving all shareholders the chance to participate. Buyback announcements also trigger a rerating of the stock, so they offer a good exit opportunity to all shareholders, irrespective of whether they participate in the buyback.

Two, the taxation of buybacks as ‘deemed dividends’ from October 2024 led to tax arbitrage. Investors ended up paying high rates of tax at slab rates on shares sold to the company during the buyback, while share sales outside of this attracted lower capital gains tax. This anomaly was removed in the latest Budget, with buybacks now subject to the same capital gains tax regime as market share sales. On worries about vested interests manipulating stock prices through buybacks, SEBI regulations have checks and balances in place. Companies cannot buy back shares from their promoters or persons in control. They cannot launch buyback offers if their shares are thinly traded. Open market buybacks can also be executed only through the exchanges, and companies cannot buy more than 25 per cent of the average trading volume of their share on any given day. Their purchase orders must also be placed within a 1 per cent range of the last traded price of the share. These rules effectively prevent vested interests from misusing market buybacks.

SEBI’s proposal is timely. One, India Inc is sitting on a cash pile, with many companies reluctant to invest in capital expansion. Buybacks by such companies will allow surplus capital to flow back to investors, who may redeploy it in more productive avenues. Two, buybacks shrink companies’ equity base and lift their per share earnings. They can help correct valuation excesses in sections of India Inc. Most important, with foreign investors on a relentless selling spree and domestic institutions the only buyers, Indian equities are struggling with an over-supply problem. Corporate buybacks can absorb some of this excess and shore up investor confidence.

POCKET

RAVIKANTH



MADAN SABNAVIS

An issue that has been flagged of late is the outstanding forwards position of the RBI. It is around \$68 billion as of January-end at the shorter end, meaning thereby that this amount will go out of the system in course of time. This is probably one of the higher positions in the last two decades or so, with high numbers being witnessed during Covid and the Ukraine war.

Critics subtract this amount from forex reserves, which are currently \$698 billion as on March 20 to gauge the effective reserves of the country. In fact, often this is subtracted from the foreign currency assets which was at \$558 billion as of March 20 to paint a grim picture of available resources being just \$490 billion. At the rate of around \$65 per month of merchandise imports, the import cover ratio is spoken of as being 7.5 months against the conventional ratio of 10.7 months when aggregate reserves are reckoned. How to make sense of these forwards positions?

FORWARDS POSITION

The forwards position is a net outstanding forward contracts of the RBI after all their buy (long) and sell (short) positions are considered. Hence the \$68 billion position is the potential outflow of dollars from the RBI over the coming months/years. These positions arise due to three main reasons.

The first is that there have been several buy-sell swaps of dollars often in the range of \$5-10 billion undertaken by the RBI to infuse liquidity into the system. These could be for 1-3 years and will stay on the books until they are due. Such swaps are an integral part of the liquidity management framework of the RBI which targets the weighted average call rate through various measures. This measure really has nothing to do with managing the currency and is more in the nature of a monetary measure.

Second, the RBI sells (or buy) dollars in this market to send strong announcement signals to the market. Typically a sale in future tells the market that there will be infusions at a later date which, in turn, will keep speculation in check. Intuitively this is a messaging system and does not involve any sale of dollars in the spot market. This has become particularly more frequent starting from Covid time where forwards have been combined with spot sales to achieve the desired results.

Third, the RBI takes positions in the NDF market, which is the non-deliverable forwards segment, which is housed overseas. This offshore

Getting a grip on the forwards position of RBI

PRUDENT APPROACH. There has been adroit management of the RBI in this respect



GETTY IMAGES

market by definition is cash settled meaning thereby that on the due date the gains and losses are cash settled. There is no physical transfer of dollars which were dealt with. Several banks do their hedging in this market based on their domestic positions in the domestic market. Also this is an open field for speculative activity where one need not put foreign currency on the table and still hope to make gains.

Therefore, the outstanding position needs to be viewed against the backdrop of these modes of transaction of the RBI in the forwards market. Further, these positions can be rolled over just as is done in any derivative market including commodities where deliveries are not common. This means that on the due date of expiry of the contract the same can be extended for a further period of time. Therefore, forex management by

The forwards position is a net outstanding forward contracts of the RBI after all their buy (long) and sell (short) positions are considered. Hence the \$68 billion position is the potential outflow of dollars from the RBI over the coming months/years

RBI is complex and is done based on the situation to ensure that there is less volatility in the market.

CROWDING OUT RESERVES

Intuitively, it can be said that treating this \$68 billion as a necessary outflow at various periods of time need not be true. Also during the course of the time period, the RBI would independently be taking buy (long) positions in the market which will even out these payments. The RBI could also be buying dollar as spot transactions from banks in the ordinary course of activity to stabilise a strengthening rupee. Therefore, the crowding out of forex reserves due to payments on the forwards position is only a theoretical possibility and rarely will materialise and there will always be countervailing action taken to ensure that there is stability in the system.

In this context, data on the same over the last 2 years can be examined which can put the present numbers in context. The RBI presents data based on maturities of up to 1 month, 1-3 months, 3 months to one year and above 1 year. As can be surmised, those beyond a year would involve largely the swap transactions undertaken to induce liquidity into the system. Quite significantly, the ratio of maturities of above 1 year to total outstanding positions has been increasing since February 2025 from around 11.3 per cent to almost 60 per cent by January

2026. This also means that this was a fallout of the RBI providing liquidity rather than intervening in the forex market.

Now, the sum total of all outstanding positions during this period of 22 months, which were maturing in one month period, was \$325 billion. This would be the case if all deliveries of these short positions had taken place as scheduled. However, forex currency reserves (gold and SDRs are excluded to better capture the movements in only the currency assets) increased by \$13.4 billion during this period. This means that there have been several rollovers of contracts or compensatory long positions taken in the course of the period to ensure that this did not result in depletion of reserves.

What all this means is that there is adroit management of the forex position by the RBI all the time to ensure there is smooth activity in the market. This task involves looking at both the forex market as well as the liquidity issues continuously as they are inexorably linked with one another. As a central bank, both the objectives have to be met with measures that can impact the other market. This in turn is straightened out through other measures like open market operations when swaps result in liquidity management issues for the banks.

The author is Chief Economist, Bank of Baroda; views are personal

Unfortunate fallout of cyber crime investigations

There were 2.8 million cybercrime complaints in 2025. But investigation has led to unfair account freeze of small businesses

Ganga Narayan Rath
Chirayu Sharma

In the shadows of the digital boom, a new kind of “cottage industry” has emerged – one that doesn’t manufacture goods, but systematically manufactures deception. While the Netflix series *Jamtara – Sabka Number Aayega* – brought the gritty reality of rural phishing hubs into our living rooms, it was merely the opening chapter of a much larger, more dangerous story.

The series highlights an important truth — cyber fraud today is less about sophisticated hacking and more about psychological manipulation. Fraudsters impersonate bank officials, investment advisers, the police and the judiciary, using urgency and fear of law to trick individuals into sharing sensitive financial information.

India faces a dual challenge: it’s the fastest growing digital payments economy and, simultaneously, one of the most targeted nations for cyber-syndicates. The latest figure from the Ministry of Home Affairs and the Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre shows that India clocked a record 2.8 million cybercrime complaints in 2025, a 24 per cent increase from the number reported in 2024.

While aggressive real-time intervention by authorities — leveraging the Citizen Financial Cyber Fraud

Reporting and Management System – saved over ₹8,000 crore, the total financial drain remained massive. Indians lost approximately ₹22,495 crore to digital criminals alone, representing a staggering 0.7 per cent of the national GDP.

As we move through 2026, the industrialisation of fraud is evidenced by the termination of over 3 crore fraudulent mobile connections by DoT and TRAI.

FREEZE FACTOR

Along with digital fraud, an unintended secondary crisis has surfaced: administrative overreach through widespread, indiscriminate debit-freezing of bank accounts. In the urgent effort to trace and recover stolen funds, law-enforcement agencies — mainly Cyber Crime Cell — have increasingly relied on account freezes as a primary investigative tool. These actions are frequently proving to be disproportionate to the suspected crime.

Data from early 2026 indicate that while 28.15 lakh cybercrime complaints were registered last year, the resulting “blanket freezes” have trapped an estimated ₹12,000 crore belonging to innocent parties. For India’s 6.4 crore MSMEs, a single suspicious credit of ₹100 can result in the total freezing of an operational account. Even a measly ₹20 credit to an unsuspecting push-cart vendor is resulting in debit-freeze.



DIGITAL PAYMENTS. Need for more vigil | ISTOCKPHOTO

This financial paralysis for small traders and salaried professionals is a violation of the fundamental right to trade and livelihood guaranteed under the Constitution.

Despite cybercrime being digital, the process of restoring frozen bank accounts remains largely physical, slow, and document-heavy. A small trader or salaried individual whose account is frozen by a cybercrime unit located in another State or region often faces what can only be described as a “justice cost”, often requiring legal assistance. This geographical and procedural disconnect has become the true “pinch point” for ordinary Indians.

With account unfreezing timelines stretching from four to seven months, businesses lose access to working capital during capital operating cycles, leading to stalled trade, missed payments and, in some cases, permanent financial

distress. Data linked to the Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre indicate that over 2.6 million “Layer 1” suspected mule accounts have been flagged as authorities attempt to track layered fraud transactions.

While such action may be essential to curb digital crime, judicial scrutiny has emphasised that blanket or indefinite freezing without proper judicial authorisation raises serious concerns of proportionality.

Addressing the growing menace of digital fraud requires a coordinated response involving individuals, financial institutions, technology platforms, enforcement authorities and sectoral regulators. Strengthening digital literacy must become the first line of defence. Nationwide financial awareness campaigns, particularly in Tier-2 and rural regions, should accompany India’s digital expansion. Banks and fintech companies must accelerate the adoption of AI-driven fraud detection systems, behavioural analytics, and real-time transaction monitoring to identify suspicious activities before financial losses occur.

Ultimately, safeguarding India’s digital future will depend not only on technological safeguards but on building a culture of digital responsibility where innovation is matched with trust, awareness, and resilience.

Rath is a former central banker and Sharma is an independent researcher. Views are personal

● **LETTERS TO EDITOR** Send your letters by email to bleditor@thehindu.co.in or by post to ‘Letters to the Editor’, The Hindu Business Line, Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002.

Mudra high

This refers to the report ‘Mudra loan disburseals hit a record ₹5.64 lakh cr in FY26’ (April 10). The scheme has popular among those engaged in low-scale economic activities who lack access to credit. The mudra loan products enabled the beneficiaries to acquire assets for their businesses and services.

For lenders, retail loans are more profitable and have less potential for asset quality deterioration. However, it is imperative to create awareness among borrowers.

VSK Pillai
Changanacherry (Kerala)

Sensible forecasting

This refers to the article “Charting an intellectually honest way of forecasting” (April 10). The piece rightly highlights how traditional baseline forecasts fail in today’s volatile environment. Policymakers often appear overconfident, which can mislead both markets and the public. A shift towards scenario-based forecasting is sensible, but it must be communicated clearly. Institutions should present a few realistic scenarios with transparent assumptions, not technical jargon. Regular updates, based on incoming

data, would improve credibility. Further, independent review of forecasts can reduce bias.

SM Jeeva
Chennai

Points to ponder

This refers to the news report ‘Haryana, Karnataka, Telangana are top talent magnets’ (April 10). That just six States in India are self-sufficient in net talent attraction for white-collar jobs is something other States need to ponder. States providing a business-friendly environment have done well. Besides, the study shows the reasons

for the States topping net positive talent balance are — future-ready world-class infrastructure, strong global pull, scalability and preferred career destination among others.

YG Chouksey
Pune

Cautious mode

Apropos the Editorial ‘Wait and Watch’ (April 10). The MPC’s decision to pause interest rates is a sober recognition that inflation today is driven less by demand excess than by supply shocks from war and weather. Raising rates would risk stifling growth without easing

these pressures. The real test lies in strengthening banks, managing capital flows, and sustaining rupee stability. Prudence must be matched by agility, with policy remaining transparent and data-driven. India’s credibility in navigating global headwinds will rest on balancing resilience with foresight, ensuring that monetary caution does not slip into inertia. The pause is valid, but the path ahead demands vigilance, adaptability, and a willingness to recalibrate swiftly when circumstances shift.

K Chidanand Kumar
Bengaluru

QUICKLY.

CII delegation engages with Chinese businesses

A Confederation of Indian Industry (CII) delegation, currently on a visit to China, has interacted with local businesses to explore strengthening bilateral economic cooperation. The delegation, led by CII President Rajiv Memani, is the second Indian business team to visit China following the normalisation of ties after a freeze of over five years due to the military stand-off in eastern Ladakh. **PHOTO**

Jio-BP has no plans to raise petrol, diesel prices

Jio-BP, the fuel joint venture of Reliance Industries Ltd and BP PLC, does not plan to raise fuel prices immediately despite a spike in international oil prices, its chief executive Akshay Wadhwa said. It has kept retail petrol and diesel rates steady just like public sector firms, which have not passed on the surge cost to consumers for fear of spiking inflation. **PHOTO**

Jaypee Group Founder Gaur fully backs Adani Group’s acquisition of JAL assets

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

Jaypee Group Founder Jaiprakash Gaur on Friday threw his support behind the Adani Group taking over his insolvent infrastructure firm JAL, saying he has full confidence in Gautam Adani’s leadership to take the group forward. The statement came days after rival bidder Vedanta Ltd’s Anil Agarwal claimed that Gaur wanted Jaiprakash Associates Ltd (JAL) to be in the “safe hands” of his mining conglomerate.

E-way bill generation surges to all-time high of 14 crore in March

SIGNIFICANT JUMP. Strong economic activity, year-end dispatches and robust trading boost numbers

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

Driven by year-end stock clearance, e-way bill generation surged to an all-time high of 14.06 crore in March, according to data released by the GST Network on Friday. This figure surpasses the previous record of 13.84 crore set in December 2025. This could have some impact on GST collection in April, data for which will be out on May 1. However, actual collection depends on higher consumption as GST is destination-based consumption. Also, services and movement of goods beyond a certain threshold are not included in e-way bill generation. As per Rule 138 of the CGST, 2017, every registered person involved in the move-



FORMALISATION PUSH. The government’s continued focus on technology is expanding the reporting base

ment of goods (which may not necessarily be on account of supply) of consign-ment value of more than ₹50,000 (can be lower for intra-state movement) is required to generate an e-way bill.

‘SIMPLIFIED PATH’ “A major development driving the recent surge is the

rollout of Form ENR-03. Introduced in February 2025 and maturing by March 2026, this feature allows un-registered persons (URPs) to generate e-way bills without a GSTIN,” said Vivek Jalan, Partner with Tax Connect. Further, he said that by providing a simplified path for small traders (via

ENR-03) while simultane-ously enforcing stricter val-idation for registered ones, the government has cap-tured a much larger share of actual goods movement in its data, in FY 25-26, which has peaked in March 2026.

STRONG ACTIVITY Commenting on the number, Saurabh Agarwal, Tax Part-ner at EY India, said that high e-way bill volumes in March 2026 reflects strong on-ground economic activity, driven by year-end dis-patches, inventory rational-isation, and robust trading momentum. The data clearly indicates that consumption-led demand remains resilient across sectors, in spite of geopolitical tensions across the globe. The government’s contin-ued focus on technology through e-invoicing, real-

time GSTN integration, and tighter compliance frame-works is deepening formal-isation and expanding the re-ported base. Some experts felt panic demand also was a reason of higher generation of e-way bill. According to Krishan Arora, Partner with Grant Thornton Bharat, till February, the continued surge in e-way bill signified the sustained business activ-ity in India coupled with in-creased momentum in sup-ply chain activity. “While some of the surge continued as spill over in March, with escalated war related global disruptions and economic uncertainties, the increased e-way bill activity in March could be at-tributable to contingency and panic demands, larger inventories of raw ma-terial and finished goods across the country,” he said.

Vedanta questions evaluation metrics behind selection of Adani’s bid for JAL

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

Mining giant Vedanta Group on Friday questioned the evaluation metrics adopted by lenders of Jaiprakash As-sociates Ltd (JAL), which had selected the lower bid of ₹3,400 crore from Adani En-terprises for the debt-ridden company. During proceedings of the insolvency appellate tribunal National Company Law Ap-pellate Tribunal, counsel representing Vedanta Ltd said the “valuation in the process has been used to

wipe out commercial wis-dom” by the committee of creditors (CoC). Pointing towards the eval-uation matrix used by the CoC, senior advocate Ab-hijeet Sinha asked whether it was used “to achieve value maximisation or is it being used for some other purpose”. **GUIDING TOOLS** He submitted that the eval-uation matrix, RFRP (request for resolution plan) and pro-cess note relied upon by the CoC are merely guiding tools and cannot override the core objective of the insolvency

framework, which is maxim-isation of value. Contending that Ved-anta’s bid was ₹3,400 crore higher in gross value and ₹500 crore in net present value than the resolution plan submitted by the Adani Group, Sinha alleged that there was no discussion in the CoC meeting for going for a lower bid. Vedanta’s counsel argued that the CoC, after intro-ducing a challenge process due to sub-optimal bids, ap-proved the very plan it ini-tially found inadequate, un-dermining the integrity of the process.

Swiggy Co-founder quits amid board restructuring

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Nandan Reddy, Co-founder of Swiggy, will step down from his role and move on in the coming days, according to the company’s regulatory filings. The company said Reddy will transition out to pursue independent ventures, marking the exit of one of the early architects of Swiggy’s growth from a hyperlocal food delivery start-up to a multi-category convenience platform.

PMMY@11: Funding the unfunded, powering MSME-led growth



ASHOK CHANDRA

When the Prime Minister launched the Pradhan Mantri MUDRA Yojana on April 8, 2015, the stated mission was simple: “Funding the unfunded.” Eleven years later, the scheme has evolved into one of the world’s largest mi-cro-credit programmes, fun-damentally altering how In-dia’s smallest entrepreneurs access formal finance, estab-lishing itself as a critical pil-lar in the nation’s financial inclusion architecture. As of March 2026, PMMY has disbursed loans worth ₹40.07 lakh crore through more than 57.79 crore ac-counts. The scale of dis-bursement, exceeding the gross domestic product

Bothra will be elevated to the board as Executive Di-rectors effective June 1, sub-ject to shareholder approval. Both executives have been long-time leaders within the company, playing key roles in scaling op-erations and financial strat-egy. Phani Kishan, currently Chief Growth Officer, has been instrumental in driving Swiggy’s expansion ini-tiatives, including its quick commerce vertical In-stamart. Bothra, who joined as the company’s first CFO, has overseen its financial transformation, including capital raises and its transi-tion into a publicly listed entity. Separately, the company also announced the ap-pointment of Renan De Cas-tro Alves Pinto as a nominee di-rector representing MIH In-dia Food Holdings BV, re-placing Roger Clark Rabalais, who resigned following changes in his role at Prosus.

Sa-Dhan’s Sankalp 3.0 to focus on early risk identification, stronger governance frameworks

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Sa-Dhan on Friday released the third edition of its mi-crofinance sector guardrails, which place emphasis on data-led decision-making, early risk identification, stronger governance frame-works and customer-centric practices. The RBI-recognised self-regulatory organisation (SRO) also unveiled human resource standards to be adopted by the micro-finance sector so as to bring more uniformity and efficiency in acquiring and managing the workforce. The new sectoral guidelines — Sankalp 3.0 — have been designed as a structured, outcome-driven framework that balances regulatory expectations with industry ownership, accord-ing to a Sa-Dhan statement. “The guidelines focus on



SAFETY MEASURE. The self regulatory organisation also unveiled human resource standards to be adopted by the sector

ensuring that growth in the sector is sustainable, re-sponsible, and aligned with long-term customer well-be-ing. It further introduces a more participatory approach to policy adoption through a consultative process in-volving multiple stakehold-ers and based on the study outcomes,” the SRO said. Sa-Dhan observed that the new set of guardrails come in the wake of an improved

situation in the micro-fi-nance sector with regards to collection efficiency and bet-ter asset quality. However, it decided to continue the ex-isting guardrails — Sankalp 1.0 and Sankalp 2.0 — for some more time for better recovery of the sector. **NEW APPROACH** Speaking a Sa-Dhan con-clave, Satish Marathe, Mem-ber, Central Board of RBI,

RBI unveils ‘Utkarsh 2029’ for currency management

Our Bureau
Mumbai



The RBI plans to advance Project Sa-Mudra to mod-ernise currency manage-ment systems and signif-icantly expand the use of central bank digital cur-rency (CBDC) to enable more effi-cient cross-border pay-ments as part of its medium-term strategy framework ‘Utkarsh 2029’. The framework also pri-oritises scaling up the unified lending interface (ULI) to improve access to credit, particularly for underserved segments. The framework (for the period April 2026 to March 2029) is based on six pillars — robust regulations, cus-tomer centricity and inclu-sive finance, competitive mar-kets, effective technology, future-ready organisation and Global India.

AI AND QUANTUM The RBI seeks to develop frameworks for use of em-erging technologies such as AI and Quantum in the finan-cial sector. Under regulations, the Central bank wants to min-imise procedural redundan-cies, empower regulated en-tities with greater operational flexibility, en-courage responsible innova-tion in present and emerg-ing realms of the financial sys-tem. Byscaling up ULI, RBI is seeking to enhance access to the financial system, reduce lending costs and promote inclusive credit delivery.

Underscoring the inter-connectedness in the finan-cial system, the bank intends to review and enhance the system-wide contagion risk assessment. Under the competitive markets pillar, the RBI will focus on deliverables that aim at reducing turnaround time of auctions, strengthen-ing pricing transparency in

the G-Secs market, and en-hancing retail access to markets. The bank will be lever-aging technology in various areas of its operations such as making the interface with regulated entities and citi-zens electronic and elimin-ate paper and/or email-based interactions. Furthermore, all internal processes shall be end-to-end digitalised. Currency management module is being augmented to digitalise manual pro-cesses and physical registers. Through cyber risk capac-ity building, issuing a framework on the use of AI in the financial sector, ex-panding asset tokenisation and setting up digital and AI sandboxes, the bank aims to promote responsible innovation. **UPI STACK** “The bank endeavours to foster greater cooperation with the rest of the world by promoting the implementa-tion of the UPI stack in other countries to modernise the payment infrastructure, aug-menting international trade settlement in INR, expand-ing cross-border CBDC ar-rangements, and adopting global standards to enhance global competitiveness,” per the Utkarsh document. RBI emphasised that this strategy framework is an in-tegral part of the roadmap to further the rupee’s global in-tegration, extend UPI to other countries, and expand bilateral and multilateral CBDC arrangements.

India to push for reporting of offshore rupee trades

Reuters
Mumbai

India plans to move ahead with a proposal mandating that banks report offshore rupee derivative trades de-spite objections from lenders, two sources familiar with the matter said, in an attempt to bring transparency to a mar-ket that has amplified pres-sure on the currency. In Feb-ruary, the Reserve Bank of India proposed that banks

report rupee foreign ex-change derivative transac-tions undertaken globally by their related parties, arguing it would support more effi-cient price discovery. The RBI wants lenders to start sharing data on at least 70 per cent of such derivative transactions, starting Feb-ruary 2027. The RBI proposal is aimed at levelling the playing field between Indian and for-eign banks, the first source familiar with the central bank’s thinking said.

**ENTERTAINMENT SOCIETY OF GOA**
Maquinez Palace, Old GMC Precinct, Campal, Panaji-Goa.
Ph no: 0832-2428111 Email: info@esg.co.in

Ref no: ESG/PR/26-27/GenAdvt/13974 Date:10/04/2026

E-Tender Notice

The Entertainment Society of Goa, Panaji-Goa invites Tenders for the work of ‘Appointment of Agency for Conceptualization, Design, Installation & Operation of high-definition Light & Sound show at Mandovi River Promenade, Panaji - Centered on the iconic statue of Bhagwan Parshuram. (Bhagwan Parshuram Jayanti).’

For detailed Advertisement visit- www.esg.co.in
DI/ADVT/78/2026

**ISGEC HEAVY ENGINEERING LIMITED**
CIN: L23423HR1933PLC00097
Registered Office: Radaur Road, Yamunanagar – 135001, Haryana
Telephone: +91-1732-661061 / 661158
Email: roynr@isgect.com, Website: www.isgect.com

NOTICE

Special Window for Re-lodgement of Transfer Requests of Physical Shares

This is to inform all concerned shareholders that pursuant to SEBI Circular No. HO/38/13/11(2)/2026-MRSD-POD/13750/2026 dated January 30, 2026, a special window for the re-lodgement of transfer deeds relating to physical securities has been opened for a period of one year from **February 05, 2026 to February 04, 2027**. Pursuant to the said circular, this Special Window is available for physical securities sold or purchased prior to **01 April, 2019** including cases where:

- Transfer requests were earlier submitted and rejected/returned/not attended to due to deficiencies in documents or processes; or
- Such transfer requests are being lodged afresh, subject to fulfillment of prescribed conditions.

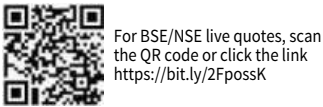
Please note that the securities so transferred under this Special Window shall be mandatorily credited to the transferee only in demat mode and shall be under lock-in for a period of one (1) year from the date of registration of transfer. Such securities shall not be transferred (lien-marked)/pledged during the said lock-in period. Concerned shareholders are advised to take note of this opportunity and re-lodge their transfer requests along with the requisite documents to the Company’s Registrar and Share Transfer Agent (‘RTA’), i.e., **M/s Alankit Assignments Limited**, Alankit House, 4E/2, Jhandewalan Extn, New Delhi-110055, Tel: 011- 42541234, 23541234; Email: rta@alankit.com or ramap@alankit.com.

Re-launch of 100 Days Campaign – ‘Saksham Niveshak’

This is to inform all concerned shareholders that pursuant to Investor Education and Protection Fund Authority (‘IEPFA’) email dated March 27, 2026, the Company has re-launched 100 days campaign ‘Saksham Niveshak’ starting from **April 01, 2026 to July 09, 2026**. During this Campaign all the Shareholders who have not claimed their Dividend or have not updated their KYC & Nomination details or face any issues related to unclaimed dividends and shares may write to the Company’s Registrar and Transfer Agent (‘RTA’), i.e., **M/s Alankit Assignments Limited**, Alankit House, 4E/2, Jhandewalan Extn, New Delhi-110055 or at e-mail Id: rta@alankit.com or ramap@alankit.com, Tel: 011- 42541234, 23541234 and further e-mail to be sent to the Company’s e-mail Id at roynr@isgect.com.

For Isgect Heavy Engineering Limited Sd/-
Kalyan Ghosh
Compliance Officer
Membership No. A10790

Place : Noida
Date : 10.04.2026



For BSE/NSE live quotes, scan the QR code or click the link https://bit.ly/2fpossk

QUICKLY.

Tech leads rally in S&P 500, Nasdaq at open



The S&P 500 and the Nasdaq edged higher on Friday, lifted by gains in tech stocks after March inflation data met expectations despite ongoing pressures from the West Asia conflict, while investors weighed the strained truce between the US and Iran. US consumer prices increased the most in nearly four years in March, as the war boosted oil prices and the pass-through from tariffs persisted. Traders stuck to bets that the US Federal Reserve will hold borrowing costs steady this year, according to data compiled by LSEG. At 10.15 am ET, the Dow Jones fell 109.60 points, the S&P 500 rose 10.56 points and the Nasdaq added 123.70 points. REUTERS

Vishal Nirmiti gets SEBI nod for IPO

New Delhi: Civil engineering, manufacturing and construction firm Vishal Nirmiti Ltd has secured SEBI's approval to garner funds through an initial public offering (IPO), an update with the markets regulator showed on Friday. The proposed IPO comprises a fresh issue of equity shares aggregating up to ₹125 crore, along with an offer-for-sale (OFS) of 15 lakh equity shares by the promoter, according to the draft papers. The Pune-based company, which filed preliminary IPO papers with SEBI in December, obtained its observations on April 9. In regulatory terms, SEBI's observation is equivalent to clearance for launching a public issue. **PH**

BROKER'S CALL.

DAM Capital

JM FINANCIAL (BUY)
Target: ₹160
CMP: ₹134.05
JM Financial is India's leading integrated and diversified financial services group. With a legacy spanning over five decades, the firm has expertise across businesses including corporate advisory and capital markets, wealth and asset management, private markets and affordable home loans. While JM Financial continued to maintain its leadership position in Corporate Advisory and Capital Markets (which includes investment banking, institutional equities, and research), the company's earnings were weighed down by legacy balance sheet exposures post covid. Historically, JM Financial had been a relatively large player in real estate financing, with meaningful on-balance sheet exposure to the sector (including land financing), alongside exposure to distressed credit/ARC assets. Given that from hereon, the focus of the Company is on high growth and high RoE businesses unlike earlier which were balance sheet heavy businesses, along with a high dividend payout ratio, the overall RoEs of the company is expected to improve from hereon. We have modelled RoE to increase from 9.4 per cent in FY25 in 12-13 per cent in FY28E. Given the low capitalisation needs and a free cash flow generated in the group (specially from the CACM segment and private markets), the dividend payout ratio is expected to remain strong. At CMP there is hardly any value assigned to the wealth, AMC and private markets We value JM Financial on a SOTP basis and arrive at a target price of ₹160 and initiate coverage with a Buy rating.

Elara Securities

PHYSICSWALLAH (BUY)
Target: ₹140
CMP: ₹101.76
Physicswallah (PWL) has mastered an omnichannel education playbook: foster trust and engagement first, monetise later. Its community-led digital funnel — anchored by flagship JEE and NEET courses, expanding vernacular and category depth, and low-barrier entry — now fuels paid online cohorts and a higher-ARPU offline network. With momentum in engagement, enrolments and centre expansion, we expect a revenue CAGR of 27 per cent and EBITDA CAGR of 84.7 per cent during FY25-28E, with adjusted PAT turning positive in FY27E and rising to ₹6.7 lakh crore by FY28E. PWL's low-CAC model turns trust into enrolments and engagement into revenue. Free content draws learners, who upgrade to paid courses, tests, doubt-solving, and tools, bypassing heavy marketing. The flywheel scales robustly: 134 million social followers, 83 million app downloads, about 3.4 million daily active users (DAU), and 4.37 million paid enrolments in 9M-FY26. Engagement metrics guide targeted expansion by city, category and segment, transforming community reach into scalable revenue. We initiate on PWL with a Buy rating and a target price of ₹140 once offline utilisation improves and the cash engine funds adjacencies without balance sheet strain. **Key risks:** Regulatory changes in coaching may impact pricing and growth; and slower offline utilisation and faculty retention issues may delay margin.

businessline is not responsible for the recommendations sourced from third party brokerages. Reports may be sent to: **blmarketwatch@gmail.com**

Inflows into gold ETFs slide 56% in March as metal price falls sharply

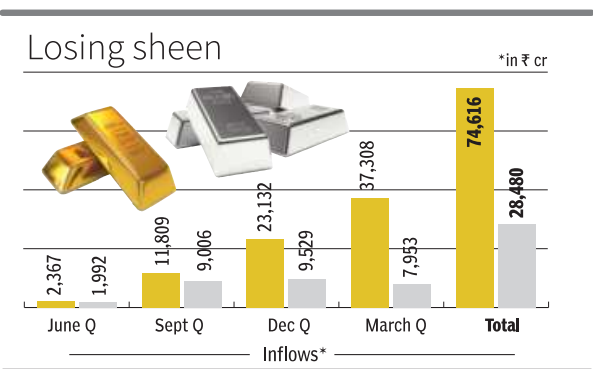
REBALANCING ACT. Silver ETF outflows moderate to ₹684 crore, signalling shift towards equities, risk assets

Our Bureau
Mumbai

After a steady rally in recent months, a sharp correction in precious metal prices has prompted investors to trim allocations to gold and silver exchange-traded funds (ETFs). Inflows into gold ETFs plunged 56 per cent to ₹2,266 crore, compared with a record ₹5,255 crore in February, as the sudden price drop dented sentiment. The category had seen strong traction earlier, with inflows of ₹24,040 crore in January, driven by risk aversion, portfolio rebalancing and momentum in gold prices. Despite the month-on-month slowdown, gold ETFs logged robust

quarterly inflows of ₹31,561 crore in the March quarter, underscoring their dual role as a tactical hedge and a strategic portfolio allocation. Assets under management (AUM) declined to ₹1.71 lakh crore from ₹1.83 lakh crore in the previous month, largely due to mark-to-market losses, according to data from the Association of Mutual Funds in India.

INVESTOR INTEREST
Nehal Meshram, Senior Analyst at Morningstar Investment Research India, said that while inflow momentum has moderated, investor interest in gold-backed products remains intact. The positive flows in March indicate that gold continues to serve as a diver-



sification tool amid market uncertainty and macro volatility. Gold ETFs remain attractive as they offer a liquid, transparent and convenient route to gain exposure without the challenges of holding physical gold, he added. Gold prices fell 8 per cent

to ₹1,46,126 in March, as investors shifted towards crude oil. Globally, LBMA gold prices dropped 12 per cent to \$4,608 an ounce, marking their weakest monthly performance since June 2013. Meanwhile, silver ETF outflows eased to ₹684 crore

Sun Pharma slumps 4% on talks of acquiring US-based Organon

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Sun Pharmaceutical Industries' shares closed down almost 4 per cent at ₹1,654.70 on BSE, following reports that the drugmaker was close to sealing a \$12 billion deal for US-based Organon, its biggest transaction yet. Sun Pharma Founder and Executive Chairman Dilip Shanghvi had told analysts in January, the company was looking for acquisitions - but they would be "disciplined" in their approach, and not shy away from raising debt. He was speaking to analysts following the com-

pany's financial performance for the third quarter ended December 31, 2025. **'SPECULATIVE'** In a clarification to BSE, Sun Pharma said: "the information set out in the article is speculative in nature and there is no material event/information that requires disclosure under Regulation 30 of the Listing Regulations." A pharma analyst told *businessline* that Sun Pharma had a good record of buying companies and integrating it — be it Israel's Taro Pharma or India's Ranbaxy, for example. However, this time around, the market was wary, as it was a large acquisition to

digest, and Organon had a \$9 billion debt. Organon is a women's healthcare company and a pharma industry insider said, the company was looking to strengthen its position in the US, given the demands by the present administration for a local footprint. Besides women's health products, Organon also had a biosimilar portfolio that could bolster Sun Pharma's plans to bulk-up its innovation pipeline, he said. Organon did not comment on the report of a Sun Pharma overture, so far. However, the company's shares surged over 28 per cent to \$8.85 (at 8.30 pm IST) in NYSE.

SEBI unearths ₹2,950-crore ponzi-like network, fines Trdez Investment ₹1 crore

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) has uncovered a case where a stock broking licence was allegedly used as a front to run a Ponzi-like scheme promising assured monthly returns of 10-12 per cent; the regulator has imposed ₹1 crore penalty on Trdez Investment Pvt Ltd. SEBI said the broker was part of a wider network of entities including Infinite Beacon, IB Prop Desk and Sispay TFS, that together mobilised over ₹2,950 crore

from investors by misrepresenting their association with a SEBI-registered intermediary.

MULTIPLE FRONTS

According to the order, agents used the broker's registration to build credibility, luring investors with promises of high fixed returns. Funds were routed through multiple entities with common directors, addresses and financial linkages, while investors were shown dashboards reflecting fictitious gains and allowed limited withdrawals initially to build trust. "Directors of Noticee



along with certain connected persons had created several partnership firms that had mobilised money from the public... and despite receiving multiple complaints... it failed to take any meaningful action," the order said.

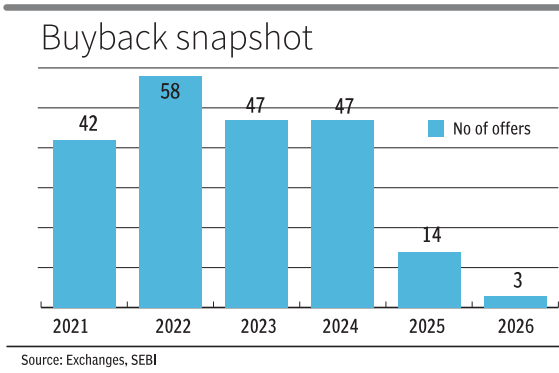
stocks advanced, while banking stocks posted firm gains... IT stocks underperformed as concerns over AI-related disruptions prompted profit-taking," said Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments. Auto and realty led sectoral gains, rising over 2.5 per cent, with Nifty Auto and Nifty Realty both clocking pull-backs of nearly 13 per cent and 19 per cent from their recent lows. Eicher Motors and Asian Paints were the top Nifty gainers. IT was the session's lone laggard, falling 1.7 per cent, dragged by TCS results and lingering concerns about AI-led disruptions. Broader markets continued to outperform benchmarks, with Nifty Midcap 100 and Smallcap 100 gaining 1.52 per cent and 1.65 per cent, respectively. Coal India was the session's biggest drag, as concerns mounted over margin compression from rising input costs.

Greenlight open market buybacks, but stay cautious

RINGSIDE VIEW.
KS BADRI NARAYANAN

India Inc's open market buyback offers are set to resume after a year-long pause, following SEBI's decision to revive the route. Several industry and market veterans had flagged concerns over the suspension of open-market buyback. Former Infosys CFO and board member TV Mohandas Pai was particularly vocal, urging the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) to allow listed entities to resume buybacks to support stock prices and stabilise markets amid sharp corrections. In a recent consultation paper, the market regulator proposed re-enabling buybacks of shares and other such securities through stock exchanges. **CHANGE OF STANCE** "Under the open market buyback through stock exchange, there existed a possibility that the entire pur-

chase order of the company could get matched with the sale order placed by one or very few shareholders. There is also a possibility that other shareholders who wanted to participate in the buyback could remain deprived of such opportunity," SEBI said. This was viewed as contrary to the principle of equitable shareholder treatment, as acceptance was a matter of chance due to the price-time matching mechanism, rather than a fair and proportionate process. Another major concern relating to buyback, according to SEBI, was the taxation framework. "At that time, taxation of buy-back was governed by Section 115QA of the Income Tax Act, 1961, which required the company to pay buy-back tax, with no tax liabilities in the hands of shareholders on gains made by successful participants. While some shareholders could offload their entire shareholding through matching orders without paying tax, others who wanted to participate but whose offers did not match remained deprived of tax ex-



emptions, rendering the buy-back from open market through stock exchange inequitable from a taxation perspective," the regulator noted. However, the buyback offer through the tender route via bourses continued to be available for corporates, with cash-rich companies preferring this mechanism to return capital. **BUYBACKS DWINDLE** Following the restriction on open market buybacks, the number of such offers fell sharply. In 2022, 58 companies announced buybacks, while both 2023 and 2024 saw 47

stock exchange may be re-introduced, subject to appropriate regulatory provisions and compliance mechanism. The re-introduction of this method of buy-back would provide companies with an additional mechanism for undertaking buy-back, while ensuring equitable opportunity and treatment of taxation for public shareholders," it further stated. So far, heavy selling by foreign portfolio investors has largely been absorbed by retail investors and mutual funds. If permitted, corporate buybacks could emerge as a key stabiliser. Their buying would also signal management's optimism in the company's future, thereby strengthening overall shareholder sentiment. Free market proponents never agree with any regulatory intervention in market movements, but many now argue that the time is right to reintroduce the scheme, given SEBI's view that recent tax changes ensure equitable treatment. However, the regulator must remain vigilant to prevent potential stock price manipulation by some greedy promoters.

Godrej Properties rises on record FY26 results

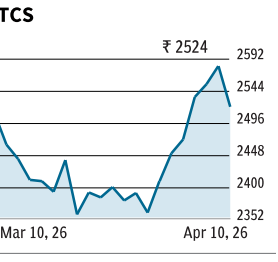
Our Bureau
Mumbai

Shares of Godrej Properties edged higher on Friday, gaining 1.24 per cent to ₹1,716.50, after the company reported its strongest-ever annual performance across bookings, collections, and operating cash flow for FY26. The stock opened at ₹1,738 and touched an intraday high of ₹1,751.10 before paring some gains, against a previous close of ₹1,695.50. The stock's move follows the company reporting FY2026 booking value of ₹34,171 crore, up 16 per cent year-on-year and the highest ever by any Indian listed real estate developer. Collections rose 17 per cent to ₹19,965 crore, while operating cash flow grew 5 per cent to ₹7,830 crore.

TCS falls post Q4, but analysts remain bullish

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Shares of Tata Consultancy Services declined 2.5 per cent to close at ₹2,501.10 on Friday after a rare annual revenue decline overshadowed strong deal wins and a quarterly earnings beat, raising concerns that a sustained growth recovery remains elusive amid weak discretionary spending and rising cost pressures. In Q4 FY26, TCS reported a net profit of ₹13,784 crore, marking a 12 per cent y-o-y increase driven by steady revenue growth and robust order bookings. Sequentially, PAT surged 28.5 per cent, aided by the absence of one-off expenses that had impacted the previous quarter. Analysts pointed to continued weakness in discre-



tionary spending across key markets, along with margin pressures from rising costs, as factors likely to weigh on performance of TCS. **POSITIVE OUTLOOK** Despite the sharp market reaction, several brokerages maintained a constructive stance on TCS, citing its strong deal pipeline and long-term growth fundamentals. Still, near-term headwinds in global IT spending continue to cloud visibility, keeping investors cautious

about the pace of recovery. Choice Institutional Equities' analyst Dhanshree Jadhav said the Q4FY26 performance surpassed estimates on the back of solid execution and robust deal wins, which improve growth visibility despite a challenging macro environment. It maintained "buy" rating with a target price of ₹3,350. Domestic brokerage Motilal Oswal expects TCS to deliver modest USD revenue and EPS CAGR of around 3.8 per cent and 7 per cent over FY26-28, with growth limited to select pockets and margins likely to stay flat, reiterating a "buy" with a target price of ₹3,000. Elara Capital maintained an "Accumulate" rating with a higher target price of ₹2,780, citing steady international momentum and data centre traction. JM Financial retained an Add rating with a

revised target price of ₹2,730, noting an in-line quarter and flagging that sector re-rating may remain constrained amid GenAI concerns, with rupee depreciation offering near-term margin support. Among global brokerages, CLSA rated the stock "outperform" with a target price of ₹2,985, while JPMorgan maintained "overweight" with a target price of ₹3,150, highlighting strong revenue performance and robust deal wins. Goldman Sachs kept a "buy" rating with a target price of ₹2,710, pointing to broad-based growth and improving stability in key accounts, and Nomura reiterated "buy" at ₹2,930, while HSBC maintained "hold" at ₹2,275. But Jefferies remained cautious, reiterating "underperform" and cutting its target price to ₹2,275, citing subdued growth outlook.

Nifty 50 Movers					▲ 275.50 pts.				
	Close(%)	Pts	PE	WN(%)		Close(%)	Pts	PE	WN(%)
ICICI Bank	1321.90	63.32	16.72	8.57	Tata Motors	444.55	111.80	99.41	3.88
HDFC Bank	810.30	42.07	16.11	11.25	Cummins India	5138.70	88.20	63.54	2.90
Reliance Ind	1350.20	29.77	18.69	8.27	Adani Energy Solutions	1157.90	77.51	58.35	1.68
State Bank	1096.70	23.31	11.38	4.02	Tes Motor Cmp	3839.90	74.78	59.74	3.76
Avis Rent	1350.80	20.22	15.89	3.52	Sarnamdhonsoninternatl	122.16	65.72	35.43	2.26
M&M	3259.80	18.13	23.98	2.64	Hdfc Amc	2619.30	59.99	39.05	2.23
L&T	3959.90	16.32	28.71	4.22	Divis Lab	6116.50	58.83	65.50	3.24
Bajaj Finance	924.55	12.43	31.39	2.24	Cholamandalamin&Fin	1581.20	58.15	27.79	2.83
Shriram Finance Ltd.	1027.55	9.55	21.14	1.31	Hindustaneronautics	4112.20	42.47	30.91	3.26
Asian Paints	2360.70	8.99	57.30	0.97	Siemens	3388.50	41.42	76.11	1.25
Eicher Motors	7424.00	8.30	38.01	0.93	Adani Power	175.81	40.63	30.01	2.03
Bajaj Auto	9813.50	7.17	30.87	0.99	Vedanta	745.15	39.09	17.59	5.28
Bharti Airtel	1870.00	7.10	30.75	5.21	Adanigreenenergy	1085.35	38.61	96.32	1.52
Titan	4505.00	5.87	83.92	1.69	Abb India	6859.50	36.35	86.19	1.50
Bajaj Finserv	1809.20	5.23	15.08	0.95	Varun Beverages	431.60	33.61	47.67	2.47
Int'lGlobeWrl	4554.20	5.19	54.84	0.93	Indian Hotels Co.	641.50	30.74	42.19	2.35
PowerGrid Corp	302.75	4.59	18.14	1.24	MuthootFin	3573.90	29.88	16.58	1.60
Adani Ports	1475.30	4.49	27.20	0.99	Macrotech Developers	434.90	28.16	4.30	2.64
Hind Unilever	2155.30	4.28	50.36	1.73	Britannia Ind	5557.50	27.44	55.40	2.73
Tata Motors PV	342.60	4.27	46.59	0.65	Union Bank	180.93	26.67	7.62	1.52
Kotak Bank	374.55	4.26	19.82	2.50	Tata Power	399.35	21.98	25.48	2.79
Eternal Ltd	240.23	3.68	1003.59	1.57	Punjab Natl Bank	1079.20	21.51	7.19	0.85
UltraTech Cement	11589.90	3.64	44.14	1.24	Canara Bank	140.15	21.32	6.90	1.97
Maruti Suzuki	13709.00	3.44	28.87	1.63	Jindal Steel	1219.20	20.49	61.69	1.88
Nestle India	1249.30	3.22	73.86	0.81	Cg Power & Ind Sol	731.10	20.34	103.78	2.09
Trent Ltd	3916.50	3.19	85.95	0.79	Ambuja Cements	445.20	19.20	22.36	1.13
Jio Financial Services Ltd.	24.30	3.12	96.28	0.72	Torrent Pharma	4155.20	17.92	61.90	1.81
HDFC Life	604.15	3.04	68.96	0.59	Godrej Consumer	106.70	16.75	60.56	1.81
Dr Reddys Lab	1232.20	2.70	18.62	0.68	United Spirits	1268.20	15.43	53.63	1.56
Adani Enter	2026.80	2.63	17.04	0.49	Gail (India)	154.08	14.16	11.77	1.73
ITC	304.25	2.63	18.41	2.66	Bosch	37330.00	13.71	39.94	1.35
Tata Steel	206.61	2.54	28.28	1.55	Indian Oilcorp	142.96	13.61	5.48	2.23
TataConsumerProduct	1093.70	2.23	73.55	0.65	Shree Cement	24340.00	13.21	48.89	1.36
Bharat Elec	442.45	2.11	54.24	1.44	DF	569.60	12.04	31.84	1.52
Hindalco	992.10	2.04	13.87	1.30	Bpcl	299.35	11.44	5.28	2.53
SEB Life	158.90	1.92	77.01	0.85	Siemens Energy India	2813.50	11.43	84.82	1.04
NTPC	380.15	1.55	14.85	1.63	Hyundai Motor India	1796.40	11.31	25.21	1.07
Wipro	204.88	1.25	16.12	0.53	Rural Elec	349.80	10.58	5.34	1.82
JSW Steel	1214.80	1.04	38.25	1.03	Bajaj Holdings	9997.50	10.39	12.41	1.81
Apollo Hosp	7511.50	0.67	57.89	0.70	Bank Of Baroda	276.19	10.21	7.27	2.14
Cipla	1229.50	0.63	21.91	0.63	Indian Railway Finance Corp	1430.26	9.97	83.41	0.84
Grasim Ind	212.60	0.31	19.15	0.85	Solar Industries	14073.00	9.97	83.41	0.84
Max Healthcare	953.35	-0.26	65.37	0.64	Zydusliscences	915.40	9.29	18.33	0.96
ONGC	286.50	-1.78	8.01	1.01	Pidlitind	1357.10	8.49	59.69	1.76
Tech Mahindra	1440.20	-2.96	30.74	0.83	Hindus Zinc	564.60	7.47	20.21	1.02
HCL Tech	1451.20	-3.15	23.91	1.39	Mazagon Dock	2470.20	7.44	41.40	0.78
Coal India	434.10	-9.91	8.99	0.89	Tata Capital	326.60	0.55	30.36	0.59
Sun Pharma	1654.90	-14.37	36.25	1.59	Avenuesuper	4400.60	-6.23	39.98	2.70
TCS	2524.30	-14.41	19.04	2.34	Ltintimtree	4503.70	-17.89	28.27	1.74
Infosys	1292.50	-29.91	18.72	4.11					
Pts: Impact on index movement									

Nifty Next 50 Movers					▲ 1,372.60 pts.				
	Close(%)	Pts	PE	WN(%)		Close(%)	Pts	PE	WN(%)
Tata Motors Cv	444.55	111.80	99.41	3.88	Adani Energy Solutions	1157.90	77.51	58.35	1.68
Cummins India	5138.70	88.20	63.54	2.90	Tes Motor Cmp	3839.90	74.78	59.74	3.76
Adani Energy Solutions	1157.90	77.51	58.35	1.68	Sarnamdhonsoninternatl	122.16	65.72	35.43	2.26
Tes Motor Cmp	3839.90	74.78	59.74	3.76	Hdfc Amc	2619.30	59.99	39.05	2.23
Sarnamdhonsoninternatl	122.16	65.72	35.43	2.26	Divis Lab	6116.50	58.83	65.50	3.24
Hdfc Amc	2619.30	59.99	39.05	2.23	Cholamandalamin&Fin	1581.20	58.15	27.79	2.83
Divis Lab	6116.50	58.83	65.50	3.24	Hindustaneronautics	4112.20	42.47	30.91	3.26
Cholamandalamin&Fin	1581.20	58.15	27.79	2.83	Siemens	3388.50	41.42	76.11	1.25
Hindustaneronautics	4112.20	42.47	30.91	3.26	Adani Power	175.81	40.63	30.01	2.03
Siemens	3388.50	41.42	76.11	1.25	Vedanta	745.15	39.09	17.59	5.28
Adani Power	175.81	40.63	30.01	2.03	Adanigreenenergy	1085.35	38.61	96.32	1.52
Vedanta	745.15	39.09	17.59	5.28	Abb India	6859.50	36.35	86.19	1.50
Adanigreenenergy	1085.35	38.61	96.32	1.52	Varun Beverages	431.60	33.61	47.67	2.47
Abb India	6859.50	36.35	86.19	1.50	Indian Hotels Co.	641.50	30.74	42.19	2.35
Varun Beverages	431.60	33.61	47.67	2.47	MuthootFin	3573.90	29.88	16.58	1.60
Indian Hotels Co.	641.50	30.74	42.19	2.35	Macrotech Developers	434.90	28.16	4.30	2.64
MuthootFin	3573.90	29.88	16.58	1.60	Britannia Ind	5557.50	27.44	55.40	2.73
Macrotech Developers	434.90	28.16	4.30	2.64	Union Bank	180.93	26.67	7.62	1.52
Britannia Ind	5557.50	27.44	55.40	2.73	Tata Power	399.35	21.98	25.48	2.79
Union Bank	180.93	26.67	7.62	1.52	Punjab Natl Bank	1079.20	21.51	7.19	0.85
Tata Power	399.35	21.98	25.48	2.79	Canara Bank	140.15	21.32	6.90	1.97
Punjab Natl Bank	1079.20	21.51	7.19	0.85	Jindal Steel	1219.20	20.49	61.69	1.88
Canara Bank	140.15	21.32	6.90	1.97	Cg Power & Ind Sol	731.10	20.34	103.78	2.09
Jindal Steel	1219.20	20.49	61.69	1.88	Ambuja Cements	445.20	19.20	22.36	1.13
Cg Power & Ind Sol	731.10	20.34	103.78	2.09	Torrent Pharma	4155.20	17.92	61.90	1.81
Ambuja Cements	445.20	19.20	22.36	1.13	Godrej Consumer	106.70	16.75	60.56	1.81
Torrent Pharma	4155.20	17.92	61.90	1.81	United Spirits	1268.20	15.43	53.63	1.56
Godrej Consumer	106.70	16.75	60.56	1.81	Gail (India)	154.08	14.16	11.77	1.73
United Spirits	1268.20	15.43	53.63	1.56	Bosch	37330.00	13.71	39.94	1.35
Gail (India)	154.08	14.16	11.77	1.73	Indian Oilcorp	142.96	13.61	5.48	2.23
Bosch	37330.00	13.71	39.94	1.35	Shree Cement	24340.00	13.21	48.89	1.36
Indian Oilcorp	142.96	13.61	5.48	2.23	DF	569.60	12.04	31.84	1.52
Shree Cement	24340.00	13.21	48.89	1.36	Bpcl	299.35	11.44	5.28	2.53
DF	569.60	12.04	31.84	1.52	Siemens Energy India	2813.50	11.43	84.82	1.04
Bpcl	299.35	11.44	5.28	2.53	Hyundai Motor India	1796.40	11.31	25.21	1.07
Siemens Energy India	2813.50	11.43	84.82	1.04	Rural Elec	349.80	10.58	5.34	1.82
Hyundai Motor India	1796.40	11.31	25.21	1.07	Bajaj Holdings	9997.50	10.39	12.41	1.81
Rural Elec	349.80	10.58	5.34	1.82	Bank Of Baroda	276.19	10.21	7.27	2.14
Bajaj Holdings	9997.50	10.39	12.41	1.81	Indian Railway Finance Corp	1430.26	9.97	83.41	0.84
Bank Of Baroda	276.19	10.21	7.27	2.14	Solar Industries	14073.00	9.97	83.41	0.84
Indian Railway Finance Corp	1430.26	9.97	83.41	0.84	Zydusliscences	915.40	9.29	18.33	0.96
Solar Industries	14073.00	9.97	83.41	0.84	Pidlitind	1357.10	8.49	59.69	1.76
Zydusliscences	915.40	9.29	18.33	0.96	Hindus Zinc	564.60	7.47	20.21	1.02
Pidlitind	1357.10	8.49	59.69	1.76	Mazagon Dock	2470.20	7.44	41.40	0.78
Hindus Zinc	564.60	7.47	20.21	1.02	Tata Capital	326.60	0.55	30.36	0.59
Mazagon Dock	2470.20	7.44	41.40	0.78	Avenuesuper	4400.60	-6.23	39.98	2.70
Tata Capital	326.60	0.55	30.36	0.59	Ltintimtree	4503.70	-17.89	28.27	1.74
Avenuesuper	4400.60	-6.23	39.98	2.70					
Ltintimtree	4503.70	-17.89	28.27	1.74					
Pts: Impact on index movement									

QUICKLY.

2.22 lakh appeals disposed of last fiscal: CBDT chair

New Delhi: The Income Tax Department disposed of 2.22 lakh appeals during the last financial year, a nearly 29 per cent increase compared to the previous fiscal as part of its efforts to reduce disputes with taxpayers, according to official data. Officials told PTI that CBDT Chairman Ravi Agrawal wrote a fiscal-end letter to the department's staffers praising their efforts for the past year.

DGFT rolls out process for calcined coke allocation

New Delhi: The Commerce Ministry's arm DGFT on Friday rolled out a procedure for import of calcined petroleum coke (CPC) for use in the aluminium industry. The Directorate General of Foreign Trade (DGFT) invited applications for the same. The quantity will be allocated based on the recommendations of an Exim Facilitation committee, it said.

Textile, garments exports to the US down 28.7% in February

NOT YET OVER. Exporters hope for revival post reciprocal tariff withdrawal

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

India's textile and garment exports to the US plummeted 28.7 per cent year-on-year (y-o-y) in February 2026, marking the sixth consecutive month of decline since the imposition of reciprocal tariffs in August 2025, per an industry analysis.

According to figures collated by the Confederation of Indian Textile Industry (CITI), exports to India's largest market for textiles and garments dropped to \$0.63 billion.

While India's contraction was significant, largely owing to the 25 per cent reciprocal tariffs (removed after the February 20 Supreme Court verdict and later replaced with a global tariff of 10 per cent) and another 25



AT STAKE. Exports to the US, India's largest market for textiles and garments, dropped to \$0.63 billion, according to the Confederation of Indian Textile Industry

per cent penal tariffs for its Russian oil imports (which were removed on February 7), other major exporting countries saw varying results.

BLOW TO OTHERS

China, which was at the receiving end of multiple and fast-changing tariffs in the US through 2025, posted a steeper decline of 45.2 per cent in February 2026, with

exports falling to \$1.04 billion. Vietnam, slapped with a lower 20 per cent reciprocal tariff by the US last year, demonstrated notable resilience, posting a 5 per cent growth to reach \$1.35 billion in February 2026.

With the landmark US Supreme Court ruling on February 20 striking down the US reciprocal tariffs, exporters welcomed the potential reprieve, but remain cau-

tious regarding the speed of a market recovery.

"We missed out on the spring orders. Now summer is also going to be over. Hopefully, we can do some catching up in a couple of months," a Delhi-based exporter told *businessline*.

When demand compresses at the top of the chain, no amount of duty advantage saves you, noted Sanjay Jain, MD, TT Ltd. "The American consumer is pulling back. And when demand compresses at the top of the chain, no amount of duty advantage saves you," Jain said.

India's goods exports in February 2026 stood at \$36.61 billion, down 0.8 per cent y-o-y from \$36.91 billion in February 2025.

In CY25, India's exports of textiles and garments posted a marginal 1 per cent increase to \$9.68 billion.

Invoices financed for RXIL jump 51% to ₹1.2 lakh cr in FY26

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The Receivables Exchange of India Ltd (RXIL) on Friday said it achieved a total throughput (invoices financed) of ₹1,21,105 crore in FY26, up 51 per cent.

In the process, the cumulative value of invoices financed on RXIL's Trade Receivables Discounting System (TReDS) platform since inception (January 2017) has crossed the ₹3 lakh crore milestone, a company statement said.

RXIL has onboarded 72,000+ MSMEs and 3,400+ corporate buyers since inception, and facilitated the financing of over 1.2 crore invoices, it added.

The TReDS platform enables MSME suppliers to convert their approved receivables into cash without collateral in under 24 hours, through a transparent multi-financier bidding mechanism.

Army clears Col Purohit for Brigadier rank after Tribunal stays retirement

Dalip Singh
New Delhi



Colonel Shrikant Purohit

The Army has given its nod for the promotion of Colonel Shrikant Purohit, acquitted of charges in the Malegaon blast case last year, to the rank of Brigadier after the Armed Forces Tribunal (AFT) stayed his retirement on March 31, 2026.

Col Purohit had petitioned the AFT on the ground that his career growth was adversely impacted due to the prolonged trial in 2008 Malegaon blast case. He was one of the accused in the case before getting acquitted by a NIA court in Mumbai.

The former intelligence officer argued that the delay in the judicial process denied him a fair opportunity for promotion within the Army hierarchy. He was commissioned in the Maratha Light Infantry in 1994 but eight years later he shifted to the Intelligence Corps. He was posted at Deolali as an intelligence officer when he was accused of being involved in the Malegaon bomb blast.

were recorded on September 1, 2010, in absence of the Colonel, the AFT ruled.

The Mumbai NIA court let off Col Purohit and six others in the case, observing that the prosecution failed to establish the charges beyond reasonable doubt.

The others acquitted included former MP Sadhvi Pragya, Major (retired) Ramesh Upadhyay, Sudhakar Chaturvedi, Ajay Rahirkar, Sudhankar Dhar Dwivedi (Shankaracharya) and Sameer Kulkarni.

The explosion occurred on September 29, 2008, when a bomb attached to a motorcycle went off near a mosque in Malegaon's Bhikkur Chowk area in Maharashtra. The blast killed six people and left 95 others injured.

CASE TRANSFERRED

In 2011, the case was transferred from the Maharashtra Anti-Terrorism Squad to the National Investigation Agency.

Over the next 17 years, investigators conducted extensive inquiries and examined hundreds of witnesses, ultimately leading to the acquittal of all those accused of charges under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act, the Arms Act and other related offences.

Auto hub in Manesar hikes minimum wage after protests

Reuters
Manesar



PINCHING LIVES. Workers said they were demanding pay rises to sustain their livelihoods as food was becoming expensive and gas supplies were erratic

The auto-making State of Haryana ordered a 35 per cent hike in minimum wages on Friday, after factory workers boycotted work and staged protests this week over rising living costs as a result of the US-Israeli war on Iran.

The Haryana government said it was raising the minimum wage for unskilled workers to \$165 per month, from roughly \$120, effective April 1, a move that will help workers but will raise cost pressures for India's auto industry.

The decision comes a day after clashes between the police and workers in Manesar, located 48.28 km south of New Delhi and home to companies like Maruti Suzuki, as well as hundreds of ancillary

units that feed into it. "We urge the workers to peacefully carry on their work," Ajay Kumar, a State official, said in a video address on Friday. Factory workers have been hit hard as prices at eat-

eries have surged due to disrupted supplies of gas, prompting some to return home.

GAS CRISIS

India is battling its worst gas crisis in decades, with the government cutting supplies for industries to shield households from any shortage of cooking gas. The government's move will increase costs for the car industry, already dealing with higher raw material prices stemming from the Iran war. While Tata Motors and Mahindra have raised car prices, Maruti has warned of a similar move. India's heavy reliance on gas across the

economy — businesses of all sizes, households, agriculture and public transport — makes its factories as well as lower-income earners among the most vulnerable in Asia. Akash Kumar, who works at Munjal Showa, a supplier to motorbike maker Hero MotoCorp, said street vendors were charging double the price for a meal of bread, curry and yogurt.

Friday's decision, he said, will bring some relief. "Whatever we get, we have to be happy," he said, adding that workers had resumed duties after being told about the pay hike.

Industrial unrest in Manesar affected various

auto suppliers this week, according to *Reuters*. Workers said they were demanding pay rises to sustain their livelihoods as food was becoming expensive and gas supplies were erratic.

NO SHORTAGE

The Centre maintains there is no shortage of cooking gas for households, and it is increasing availability of smaller cylinders for daily-wage earners and migrants.

While talks between Iran and the US have raised hopes of de-escalation, auto industry executives said supply chains could take weeks to normalise, as migrant workers head back home.

Telangana's GST revenue up 15% in last 3 months

Our Bureau
Hyderabad

Telangana's revenue from Goods and Services Tax (GST) increased 15 per cent over the past three months.

Disclosing this at a meeting of a Cabinet Sub-Committee on revenue generation here on Friday, Deputy Chief Minister Bhatti Vikramarka Mallu said the Registration Department has also recorded revenue growth.

The actual numbers on revenue are yet to be released.

MODERN TECH

The use of modern technologies like AI, continuous monitoring of tax revenues across departments, and systematic administration resulted in an increased revenue generation.

The adoption of AI technology helped enhance revenue streams in depart-

ments such as mining and transport, according to the Deputy CM. He instructed officials to act more stringently against illegal sand mining, crusher operations, illegal transportation and overloading.

The Deputy Chief Minister also directed all departments to prepare plans for revenue mobilisation in line with the goal of achieving a \$3 trillion economy by 2047.

He further instructed officials of the Registration Department to present the reports of committees studying land value revisions to the Sub-Committee, and then proceed to submit them to the Cabinet.

Ministers also reviewed aspects related to metro rail acquisition, management, revenue and expenditure.

Additionally, progress in increasing revenues in the Excise, Revenue and Industries Departments was discussed, according to a release.

MAHE, Helogen partner for space-based biomedical research

Our Bureau
Chennai

Helogen Corporation, a US-based orbital industrial automation company has signed an agreement with Manipal Academy of Higher Education (MAHE) to pioneer space-based biomedical research.

This will establish a framework whereby the two entities will undertake joint planning, mission design and experiments focused on advanced biomaterial research in space. The collaboration will focus on a phased research programme for the development of organoids, including muscle organoids and bone loss studies, for both terrestrial and space-based applications.

SCOPE OF STUDY

MAHE will integrate its proprietary organoid research with Helogen's platforms for



The Manipal Academy of Higher Education (MAHE)

cutting-edge biomaterial culturing, treatment, monitoring and analysis in orbital environments.

The institution will lead the design and development of scalable experiments in alignment with emerging Indian space station initiatives, including potential future platforms such as the Bharatiya Antariksh Station (BAS), to help enable long-term, sustainable research in microgravity.

"This collaboration reflects MAHE's commitment to advancing high-impact, future-oriented research at

the intersection of biomedical science and space technology. By integrating our academic and clinical strengths with specialised orbital platforms, we aim to generate knowledge that is both scientifically rigorous and societally relevant," said Lt Gen (Dr) (retd) MD Venkatesh, Vice-Chancellor, MAHE.

"This agreement represents a significant step forward in leveraging microgravity for next-generation biomedical breakthroughs," said Shishir Bankapur, CEO of Helogen Corporation.

Hilton, Royal Orchid sign deal for 125 hotels

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Hilton has signed a strategic licensing agreement with Royal Orchid Hotels to add 125 properties under the Hampton by Hilton brand by 2035. This is the third such agreement by Hilton in recent months and will help grow its presence in South and West India. Under the deal, hotels will be managed by the Royal Orchid Group.

These will be developed in Goa, Maharashtra, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh and Telangana. "India's economic growth, expanding middle class and rapid infrastructure development are reshaping the country's travel landscape, creating significant opportunities for our brands," said Alan Watts, Hilton's President, APAC region.

'India to lead global net zero transition with 150 GW solar milestone'

G Naga Sridhar
Hyderabad

India is poised to lead the global net zero transition with the 150-GW solar milestone and 5.1 million green jobs potential, according to Union Minister for New & Renewable Energy Pralhad Joshi.

Speaking at the second edition of FICCI Net Zero Forum — 'Pathways to a climate-responsible future' held here on Friday, Joshi said India is 'firmly' resolved to lead the global transition towards net-zero emissions.

"Today, India stands as the third-largest country globally in solar power capacity, after China and the US. The country has achieved a significant milestone, with approximately 50–55 per cent of its installed electricity capacity coming from non-fossil fuel sources, including solar, wind, hydro, and nuclear energy," he said.

India's progress towards net-zero emissions could generate approximately 51 lakh (5.1 million) green jobs over the next four years, reflecting the strong linkage



Union Minister Pralhad Joshi

between climate action and economic growth, he added.

Navin Mittal, Principal Secretary, Department of Energy, Telangana, said following India's solar revolution, the next major transformation would be driven by energy storage.

COST FACTOR

India was consuming nearly 150 billion litres of petrol and diesel annually, underscoring the urgent need for cleaner alternatives, Mittal said.

He emphasised that solar-powered electric mobility can cost as low as ₹0.60 per kilometre, compared to approximately ₹10 per kilometre for fossil fuels and ₹2 per kilometre for conventional EVs.

Highlighting deepening

UK-India cooperation, Gareth Wynn Owen, British Deputy High Commissioner in Hyderabad, said significant investments such as a £1 billion (approx. \$1 billion) UK-backed project in Vijayawada, Andhra Pradesh, was a testament to growing clean energy collaboration.

Rajesh Miglani, Senior Climate Business Specialist and Climate Anchor, IFC South Asia, World Bank Group, said under the Country Partnership Framework (CPF), the World Bank Group plans to deploy \$8–10 billion annually, unlocking up to \$20 billion per year from private markets through blended finance instruments.

Apricot festivals blossom tourism season in Ladakh

Gulzar Bhat
Srinagar



TOURISM PUSH. The initiative is part of a broader push by the administration to promote off-season travel and showcase Ladakh's cultural and agricultural heritage

In a bid to extend the tourism season beyond the traditional summer months, the Tourism Department in the cold desert region of Ladakh has been organising Apricot Blossom Festivals across multiple villages, drawing inspiration from Japan's famed cherry blossom celebrations.

The festival is already underway in several locations, with apricot orchards in full bloom, transforming parts of the region into swathes of white and pale pink and attracting a growing number of travellers as well as local visitors.

"We are organising the festival in eight villages: four each in Leh and Kargil," a Tourism Department official in Leh said. "The main objective is to extend the tourism season beyond the peak summer months," he said. The initiative is part of a

broader push by the administration to promote off-season travel and showcase Ladakh's cultural and agricultural heritage.

"The broader objectives of the festival are to promote sustainable and community-based tourism, create livelihood opportunities for rural household, especially wo-

men and small farmers, and celebrate Ladakh's lesser-known spring season", said the official.

Based on trends observed over the past few years, the Apricot Blossom Festival generally attracts around 9,000–10,000 visitors annually, with numbers witnessing a sharp upward trajectory

as the festival gains wider visibility and popularity.

Known for producing high-quality organic apricots, Ladakh accounts for more than 60 per cent of India's total output of the fruit.

Around 2,612 hectares are under apricot cultivation, with annual production estimated at about 15,858 metric tonnes, according to official data.

KEY VARIETIES

Key varieties grown in the region include Halman, Rakt-say Karpo, Khantay and Narmoo, prized for their taste and suitability for both fresh consumption and processing.

Apricot cultivation is a major source of livelihood in Ladakh, supporting an estimated 40,000 to 60,000 people, while thousands more depend on the crop through processing, trade and tourism-related activities.

QUICKLY.

**FYL91's flights to connect
Hyderabad and AP cities**

Hyderabad: Pure play regional airline FLY91 on Friday commenced operations on its Hyderabad to Rajahmundry to Hyderabad and Hyderabad to Vijayawada to Hyderabad sectors. Union Civil Aviation Minister K Rammohan Naidu, Union Minister of Civil Aviation, virtually started the airline's first flight from Vijayawada Airport to Hyderabad's Rajiv Gandhi International Airport. Starting off with daily flights, the airline will ramp the frequency up to double daily services from April 17 on both routes. **OUR BUREAU**

**ISRO conducts crucial test
for Gaganyaan mission**

New Delhi: Space agency ISRO has successfully conducted the second integrated air drop test (IADT-02) for the upcoming Gaganyaan mission at the space station in Andhra Pradesh's Sriharikota. The system is essential to ensure safe recovery of the crew module — the capsule in which astronauts sit during a human flight — during re-entry and landing. **PTI**

Charter service operators urge review of ATF pricing

POLICY DISCONNECT. Industry says current classification does not reflect actual ops

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi

In light of high jet fuel costs resulting from the Gulf crisis, India's air charter providers have urged the government to revise how non-scheduled operators are categorised under aviation turbine fuel (ATF) pricing, aiming to align their rates with those of scheduled airlines.

In a submission to the Ministry of Civil Aviation, the Business Aircraft Operators Association (BAOA) stated that the current approach focuses too heavily on perceived usage rather than the actual role of non-scheduled operator permit (NSOP) services. If accepted, the request would align ATF prices with the operational utility of NSOPs, rather than treating them as luxury air services.

Notably, the Centre has supported scheduled service



CRISIS SUPPORT. The Centre has supported scheduled service providers from the impact of crude oil price volatility

providers — primarily airlines — against the impact of crude oil price volatility arising from the West Asia crisis. It had capped the increase in jet fuel prices for scheduled operators at 25 per cent, resulting in a lower effective price hike.

CONNECTIVITY BOOST According to the BAOA's submission, reviewed by *businessline*, NSOP services are a vital component of air transport, providing on-demand and last-mile con-

nectivity, particularly in areas where scheduled airlines do not operate. Furthermore, the association noted that NSOP operators connect over 400 airfields, while scheduled airlines serve fewer than 150 airports.

As per Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) data as of February 28, 2026, there are 137 non-scheduled operators managing a total of 443 aircraft, including 223 helicopters and 220 fixed-wing aircraft.

The BAOA emphasised that helicopters are used for emergency services, disaster response and connectivity in remote areas, while fixed-wing aircraft support air ambulances and regional connectivity.

However, the association argued that the view of NSOP operations as being mainly “luxury” is incorrect, adding that such use is limited and often linked to time-sensitive travel by officials and key personnel.

According to industry insiders, the Centre has executed various measures to cushion airlines against the sharp rise in operating costs driven by higher ATF prices, airspace restrictions and currency pressures.

In the absence of such interventions, they suggested that airlines may have been compelled to implement steeper fare increases, reduce capacity, and rationalise routes to maintain financial viability.

Share of employees ‘engaged’ at work on a decline, says report

Rohan Das
Chennai

The uncertainties of today's employment landscape is seemingly taking a toll on India's workforce.

According to the 2026 State of the Global Workplace report from research and analytics firm Gallup, only 23 per cent of surveyed Indian employees claim that they feel engaged at work as against 30 per cent in 2025.

The decline of 7 per cent points is among the highest in the world and is significantly higher than the global decline in employee engagement of 1 per cent point.

LEARN AND GROW

As defined by the report, employee engagement reflects the involvement and enthusiasm of employees at work when their basic needs are met, can contribute meaningfully, feel a sense of belonging and have opportunities to learn and grow.

Higher employee engagement is linked to business-unit productivity, including profitability and sales, the re-



port said. Despite the drop, the share of engaged Indian employees continues to be higher than the global average of 20 per cent. India's 2026 engagement levels is higher than peers like China (11 per cent), the UK (10 per cent) and Japan (8 per cent), but lower than the US (32 per cent).

According to Shailesh Khanna, Brand Lead-Manpower, ManpowerGroup India, despite a reasonably favourable hiring landscape, there seems to be a gap in employee experience.

PACE OF CHANGE

“The key factor seems to be the pace of change. As technology adoption accelerates, employees are constantly ad-

apting, often without enough support, which can create pressure instead of confidence,” he said.

On the other hand, he mentions that the rampant lay-offs in the technology sector have created a broader sense of uncertainty across the workforce. Other factors such as compulsory return-to-office policies, are affecting employee trust and stability, he added.

Meanwhile, the report also measures other employee well-being metrics such as stress, triumph and outlook on the job market. It showed that 28 per cent of Indian employees reported daily stress, while only 17 per cent said they were thriving at their job. More than 50 per cent said that now is a good time to find a job.

Khanna flagged that these metrics are a cause of concern.

“Even if India is performing better than some global markets, a downward trend needs attention. Over time, lower engagement can show up as higher attrition and lower productivity,” Khanna said.

Meta Platforms ‘must face Massachusetts lawsuit over youth addiction’

Reuters
Boston

Meta Platforms must face a lawsuit by Massachusetts' attorney general alleging the company designed its Instagram social media platform to addict children, the state's top court ruled on Friday.

The ruling by the Massachusetts Supreme Judicial Court marked the first time a State high court has considered whether a federal law that generally shields Internet companies from lawsuits over content posted by their users would also bar claims that companies like Meta knowingly addicted young users.

Writing for the unanimous court, Justice Dalila Argaez Wendlandt said the lawsuit brought by Massachusetts Attorney General Andrea Joy Campbell does not seek to hold Meta liable for content created by its users, which Section 230 of the Communications Decency Act of 1996 generally shields companies from, but targets the company's conduct.

META'S CONDUCT

“Instead, the claims allege harm stemming from Meta's own conduct either by designing a social media platform that capitalises on the developmental vulnerabilities of children or by affirmatively misleading consumers about the safety of the Instagram platform,” Wendlandt wrote.

Campbell, a Democrat, hailed the ruling in a state-

Thirty-four other States are pursuing similar cases against Meta in federal court

ment, calling it a “major step in holding these companies accountable for practices that have fuelled the youth mental health crisis and put profits over kids.”

Meta has denied the allegations and says the company takes extensive steps to keep teens and young users safe on its platforms.

The lawsuit is one of thousands of cases seeking to hold Meta and other social media companies responsible for allegations that they designed their platforms to be addictive to young users.

Friday's ruling followed a landmark trial in which a Los Angeles jury on March 25 found Meta and Alphabet's Google negligent for designing social media platforms that are harmful to young people. It awarded a combined \$6 million to a 20-year-old woman who said she became addicted to social media as a child.

A separate jury a day earlier found Meta owed \$375 million in civil penalties in a lawsuit by New Mexico's attorney general, accusing the company of misleading users about the safety of Facebook and Instagram and of enabling child sexual exploitation on those platforms.

Thirty-four other states are pursuing similar cases against Meta in federal court.

IPL 2026: Ad volume witnesses marginal 3% dip in first 13 matches

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

After witnessing a strong start, TV ad volumes marginally dipped during the first 13 matches of the ongoing edition of the Indian Premier League compared to the corresponding number of matches in the previous edition, as per the latest data released by TAM Sports.

“Following a strong start, IPL 2026 recorded a marginal 3 per cent dip in ad volumes, based on the like-



HIGH SCORE. E-commerce, paints and corporate financial institutions accounted for a major chunk of total ad volumes **PTI**

to-like comparison of the first 13 matches in both seasons, primarily impacted by a

rain-abandoned match and comparatively lower ad intensity during the afternoon

games,” TAM Sports, a division of TAM Media Research noted.

STARTING VOLUME

The strong start was due to a 10 per cent rise in terms of ad volumes witnessed in the first four matches of the ongoing IPL season compared to the same phase in the previous season.

Meanwhile, the count of advertisers (over 45) and categories (over 40) was also lower in the first 13 matches of IPL 19 compared to a similar number of matches in

the previous season. TAM Sports noted that there “was 22 per cent narrower category mix and 31 per cent fewer advertisers, reflecting a more concentrated, high intensity ad landscape.”

GOOGLE AT TOP

Mouth fresheners, e-commerce (other services), wallets, paints and corporate financial institutions emerged as among the top categories in terms of share of ad volumes.

“Collectively, the top five categories accounted for 45

per cent of total ad volumes,” it added.

Google led the charts with 13 per cent share of the ad volumes across these 13 matches. Reliance Consumer Products, Vishnu Packaging, Havells India and KP Pan Foods were among the top five advertisers across these 13 matches in terms of ad share.

“The top five advertisers in IPL 19 (13 matches) contributed nearly 40 per cent of the overall ad volumes, with Google taking the lead,” the report noted.

Talent glut deepens; applications for tech role rise 2x post layoffs

Sanjana B
Bengaluru

A wave of nearly 50,000 job cuts in 2026 has flooded the labour market with candidates, sharply increasing competition as applications per role surge.

According to Careernet data, mid-level positions now attract around 100 applicants within 24 hours, up from 36-48 hours previously, while tech roles are seeing a 20-25 per cent rise in applicant volumes over just five working days, with job-seekers applying more broadly across industries and roles.

Data from TeamLease Digital also indicate that post major layoffs, applications for every role have gone up by 1.5-2x across several mid-to-senior tech roles, particularly in product and program management roles.

“With thousands of job cuts, the available talent pool

of job-seekers has expanded faster than the market can absorb, driving a sharp surge in applications per role. Displaced professionals aren't just applying more but more broadly, targeting adjacent functions, different industries and roles they previously overlooked or for which they may be overqualified,” Neelabh Shukla, Chief Business Officer, Careernet, said.

DEMAND DISRUPTED

The pressure is most acute in early and mid-level positions, among candidates with 0-8 years of experience, especially across application maintenance, software engineering and support roles, where demand is being disrupted due to AI-led automation.

According to Husain Tinwala, President of upGrad Rekrut, roles seeing a flood of applications are testing and QA, support roles, legacy technology stacks, general



DEMAND HIT. The pressure is acute in early and mid-level positions, among candidates with 0-8 years of experience

software engineering and mid-management roles. On the other hand, roles where demand remains strong but are seeing a relative shortage are AI and machine learning, data engineering, cloud architecture and cybersecurity. Over half of current hiring is concentrated in emerging digital capabilities, while legacy roles continue to decline. Skill gaps in these areas are widening, which means a surge in applica-

tions is not translating into successful placements where capability gaps exist.

“The heightened competition has, in many cases, moderated salary expectations in non-niche roles, shifting some negotiation leverage back to employers,” Ganesh S Padmanabhan, VP, Recruitment Business at CIEL HR, said.

Volume-led hiring has given way to precision recruitment, with a focus on

candidates who bring specialised, immediately deployable skills, particularly in AI, data and cloud. This recalibration is showing up in pay trends too. Salary increments across India Inc are projected at around 9.1 per cent in 2026.

However, with supply outpacing demand in several roles, negotiating leverage is quietly tilting towards employers.

MANAGING COSTS

Meanwhile, both sides are leaning into flexibility — contract, freelance and project-based arrangements as companies manage costs and professionals navigate uncertainty.

“After the 2021-22 hiring spike, India's IT hiring saw a 7-10 per cent decline in FY24, while job applications per role increased significantly across platforms. Our estimates indicate 18-27 per cent growth in demand for AI, data and cybersecurity

roles. This divergence signals a demand shift towards high-skill, *niche* capabilities, moving towards a more measured, skills-led hiring cycle rather than a prolonged downturn,” Neeti Sharma, CEO, TeamLease Digital, said.

Shukla added that hiring momentum is also migrating beyond traditional tech into BFSI, healthcare and manufacturing sectors, which are increasingly hungry for tech talent. The one group navigating harder terrain is early-career professionals.

Entry-level hiring has slowed as automation reshapes foundational roles and companies prioritise job-ready talent. With roughly 1.5 million graduates entering the market annually but only 40-45 per cent employable, freshers face longer searches and sharper competition, though those skilled in AI, data engineering and cybersecurity are hired quickly.

Fintechs bet big on digital FDs, eye larger share of savings

Jyoti Banthia
Bengaluru

Fintech platforms are stepping up their play in India's fixed deposit (FD) market, betting on digital distribution, ease of access and transparency to attract a new generation of savers.

The shift comes as startups and large platforms alike look to tap into a vast pool of retail savings traditionally parked in bank deposits.

Wealthtech start-up Stable Money, which recently raised \$25 million led by Peak XV Partners, is among players doubling down on the segment. Platforms such as smallcase, WintWealth and Flipkart-backed super.money have also begun offering FDs, even if not as their core proposition.

DIGITAL PLATFORM

“Honestly by regulation there can't be any different-

iation for anybody who's booking fixed deposit either via branch or via net banking or any digital platform,” said Saurabh Jain, Co-founder and Chief Executive of Stable Money. “But the important thing that we are trying to do is solving for access and the convenience,” he added.

Jain pointed out that digital platforms are bridging a key gap by aggregating multiple banks and non-banking financial companies in one place. “Taking it digital and making it available in their mobile is giving access to all those 13 banks and NBFCs that we have on our platform through one app,” he said, adding that the entire lifecycle — from KYC to withdrawals — is now handled digitally.

For users, this means less friction compared to traditional processes that often require branch visits or relationship manager intervention. Industry executives say



such ease of use, coupled with the ability to compare rates and manage deposits seamlessly, is driving adoption among both first-time and experienced investors.

USER FIRST

At Flipkart-backed super.money, the focus is on reimagining the product experience around user needs. “While traditional FDs have largely been a bank-led static product, our app experience puts the user first throughout the journey,” said Prakash Sikaria, CEO and Founder of super.money.

He added that the plat-

form is seeing “strong adoption from both first-time investors seeking safety as well as more seasoned users diversifying their portfolios,” with FDs increasingly becoming an entry point into structured wealth creation.

Sikaria also highlighted the broader opportunity emerging around deposits.

Recently, Zerodha has introduced fixed deposits (FDs) on its investment platform Coin, as the brokerage looks to deepen its play in long-term savings products beyond mutual funds.

Coin, which operates separately from Zerodha's trading app, Kite, serves as the company's hub for long-term investments, including mutual funds, insurance and the National Pension System (NPS). With the addition of FDs, users can now allocate savings across both market-linked and fixed-income instruments on a single platform.

The feature allows cus-

tomers to compare FD rates across multiple banks, book deposits digitally, and track key metrics such as invested amount, accrued interest and maturity timelines in one place. The offering is expected to include deposits from small finance banks, which typically offer higher interest rates.

The growing activity signals intensifying competition in the digital FD space, as platforms race to capture a larger share of household savings. With India estimated to have millions of users holding significant portions of their wealth in fixed deposits, fintech firms are positioning themselves as intermediaries that simplify access while retaining the safety of traditional instruments.

As more players enter the market, the battle is likely to hinge less on rates, which remain regulated, and more on distribution, trust and user experience.

Anthropic planning to build its own artificial intelligence chips: sources

Reuters
San Francisco

Artificial intelligence lab Anthropic is exploring the possibility of designing its own chips, three sources said, as the company and its rivals respond to a shortage of AI chips needed to power and develop more advanced AI systems.

The plans are in early stages and the company may still decide to only buy AI chips and not design any, according to two people with knowledge of the matter and one person briefed on Anthropic's plans.

SPECIFIC DESIGN

The company has yet to commit to a specific design or put together a dedicated team to work on the project, one of the sources said.

Demand for its AI model



Claude has accelerated in 2026, with the startup's run-rate revenue now surpassing \$30 billion, up from about \$9 billion at the end of 2025, Anthropic said earlier this week.

Anthropic uses a range of chips, including tensor processing units (TPUs) designed by Alphabet's Google

and Amazon's chips to develop and run its AI software and chatbot Claude.

Earlier this week, Anthropic signed a long-term deal with Google and Broadcom, which helps design the TPUs.

COMPUTING INFRA

That deal builds on the company's commitment to invest \$50 billion in strengthening US computing infrastructure.

Anthropic's discussions mirror similar efforts underway at large tech companies that are seeking to design their own AI chips, including Meta and OpenAI.

Designing an advanced AI chip can cost roughly half a billion dollars, according to industry sources, as companies need to employ skilled engineers and spend to make sure the manufacturing process has no defects.

